Tax-weary Democrats thinned Middleton's 2026 referendum cushion

A research paper on the Middleton-Cross Plains Area School District operating referendums of Nov. 8, 2022 and Nov. 3, 2026. Prepared Nov. 5, 2026. All 2026 vote figures are unofficial until the county canvass, due by Nov. 17, 2026. Bracketed numbers in citations refer to the numbered reference list at the end.

Abstract

The Middleton-Cross Plains Area School District (MCPASD) operating referendum of Nov. 3, 2026 passed with **60.1% (14,263 Yes, 9,457 No, unofficial)**, 2.8 points below the **62.9% (14,596 to 8,608, official)** that the Nov. 8, 2022 question won. The four-year ask grew from $65.5M to **$118.5M**, although only about **$18.9M** of it was new money above the existing $24.9M level (Dane County 2026 [4]; Dane County 2022 [2]). Yes lost 333 votes and No gained 849, almost all in the City of Middleton (+261), the Madison wards (+260), the Village of Cross Plains (+203) and the Town of Middleton (+139); the three towns that voted No added no new No votes on net. Party still sorted the wards, but the relationship flattened, and Yes fell further behind the Democratic vote: from **13.7 to 17.1 points** behind the governor's race and from **11.4 to 17.4 points** behind the attorney-general rematch. That arithmetic requires that **at least 22% of Democratic-voting participants voted No** (Dane County governor 2026 [8]). Roll-off on the back-of-ballot question reached **7.2%**, concentrated in the City and Town of Middleton. Property data explain the slide in the Village of Cross Plains, which had the fastest appreciation, a 0.65 assessment ratio and typical-home school taxes up about 27% in two years, and in the small rural towns. They do not explain the City of Middleton, which had the slowest school-tax growth in the district and the most new No votes. There, the likeliest tax trigger was a revaluation that raised assessment notices by about a third weeks before the vote without changing anyone's share of the school levy (DOR TVC data [23]; City of Middleton [26]). The district's own tax figures changed from $44/$65/$64/$64 to $0/$21/$40/$59 per $100,000 between August and September, switched basis from 2022's assessed value to fair market value, and reached voters in at least four incompatible forms. Waunakee passed its operating and bond questions on the same ballot with only **52.6% and 51.7%**. Its electorate is 11 points less Democratic, which explains the lower share, but its operating support has fallen in every cycle since 2020, the trajectory that MCPASD's 2030 renewal, starting at $34.6M, must avoid. For 2030 the analyst should treat MCPASD's majority as a tax-trust coalition resting on a Democratic base: persuade the Democratic homeowners who defected, publish one dated tax table with an explicit basis and a fail scenario, close the roll-off gap, and archive the data the county does not keep.

1. Introduction: a familiar question at a bigger price

MCPASD has asked its voters three times in eight years to let it exceed the state revenue limit for operations. Each time it asked for more and kept a little less support. The 2018 operating question won **69.2%** (Channel 3000, 2018 [59]), the 2022 question **62.9%** and the 2026 question **60.1%**. The 2026 measure was built as a renewal. It re-authorizes the $24.9M that the 2022 referendum reaches in 2026-27 and then steps up to $34.6M by 2030-31, under a purpose

clause identical word for word to 2022's (What's on the Ballot, Nov. 2026 [15]; MCPASD 2022 presentation [31]). It ran in a hostile climate, with the statewide November school pass rate down from about 79% to about 57% (WPF via WNA [78]; Civic Media, Nov. 4 [73]). It also ran in a Democratic wave: David Crowley won the governorship by just over eight points and Democrats took both legislative chambers (Wikipedia, 2026 gubernatorial election [95]). Next door, the Waunakee Community School District put a permanent operating increase and a $97.5M bond question on the same ballot (Waunakee CSD [35]).

This paper answers seven research questions. **RQ1:** How did the 2026 result compare with 2022 overall and by ward and municipality? **RQ2:** How did turnout and roll-off change? **RQ3:** How did support correlate with Democratic and Republican voting, and did the gap between Yes and the Democratic vote grow? **RQ4:** How much did property values, assessed values and school taxes rise in the communities that voted No or added No votes, including the City of Middleton revaluation and the Village of Cross Plains? **RQ5:** What is the full, sourced record of the district's tax-impact figures, and what does the move between an assessed-value basis and a market-value basis teach? **RQ6:** How did MCPASD compare with Waunakee's questions on the same ballot? **RQ7:** What should a political analyst preparing for the next referendum ask and do differently?

The argument in brief runs as follows. The 2026 slip was not partisan polarization. It was Democratic softening, concentrated in high-value Democratic wards and in the fast-appreciating Village of Cross Plains, at the same time as a Democratic wave raised turnout without raising Yes. Tax experience explains part of the pattern, but through different mechanisms in different places: rising bills in the Village and the rural towns, and a mid-campaign revaluation notice in the City. The district's tax message muddied an argument it could have won, because the referendum rate record since 2022 is better than projected. Waunakee shows what serial operating asks do to a coalition over four cycles. The stakes are concrete. The 2026 authority expires after 2030-31, the next question will start from a $34.6M ceiling, and the 4,806-vote cushion was earned against no organized opponent.

2. Data and methods: one county feed, 29 reporting units and a stack of caveats

2.1 Sources and the status of the counts

All election returns come from the Dane County Clerk. The 2022 figures are the official canvass, labeled "Official Canvass – Finalized On: 11/15/2022 2:57 PM" in the county's export (Dane County 2022 [2]). The 2026 figures are unofficial. The precinct export reads "All Precincts Reported On: 11/3/2026 11:27 PM," the county API carries a null finalized date, and the results page states that municipal and school-district results on it are unofficial (Dane County 2026 results [3]; Dane County API [14]). Wisconsin county canvass boards must convene by Nov. 10 and certify by **Nov. 17, 2026** (Campaign Legal Center [18]). Canvass corrections usually move a handful of votes, so the 4,806-vote margin is secure, but individual ward figures may shift. Which body certifies the school question in 2026 is not settled in the sources: the county disclaimer implies districts do, while in 2022 the county itself labeled this contest "Official Canvass."

Two count discrepancies in secondary material are resolved here. Some campaign notes carried the 2022 result as 14,592 to 8,606, apparently a pre-canvass count. This paper uses the official

14,596 to 8,608, so its year-over-year changes (−333 Yes, +849 No) differ by a few votes from figures circulated earlier (−329, +851). Channel 3000's election-night count of 14,248 to 9,445 is exactly the final total minus Madison Ward 95 (15 Yes, 12 No), which had not yet reported. It is a timing artifact, not a conflicting count.

Property and school-finance data come from four public layers, supplemented by municipal assessment documents and AccessDane parcel records. The Department of Public Instruction (DPI) publishes each district's levy, its equalized value with tax-increment districts excluded ("TID-out") and its mill rate (DPI equalized tax rates [19]). The Department of Revenue (DOR) publishes the MCPASD portion of each municipality's equalized value (DOR school certification [20]), each municipality's residential value and its "economic change," which is market appreciation excluding new construction (DOR Statement of Changes [21]), the county apportionment (DOR apportionment [22]), and assessment levels and school taxes by municipality (DOR TVC data [23]). The Dane County Treasurer's 2025 mill-rate sheet gives the school rate printed on bills in each municipality and its four-decimal assessment ratio (Dane County Treasurer [25]). Zillow's mid-tier home value index supplies typical home values by city and ZIP code (Zillow ZHVI [30]). DOR keeps only three years of municipal reports online, and the Wayback Machine was unreachable, so no 2022 municipal-level value file could be retrieved. Municipal comparisons therefore start in 2023 for whole municipalities and in 2024 for MCPASD portions.

Messaging evidence comes from the district's 2022 presentation, an image-only PDF that was OCR'd and visually checked (MCPASD 2022 presentation [31]), from news coverage, from Waunakee's district materials and from a commercial referendum tracker. The MCPASD website sat behind a JavaScript challenge throughout the research, so the district's 2026 tax-impact page was never viewed directly; its figures are known from news reproductions. Claims known only from search-engine summaries are labeled secondhand in the text.

2.2 The Dane County precinct data feed

The county's "Votes by Precinct" pages are fed by a public JSON API with the pattern `https://api.danecounty.gov/api/v1/elections/precinctresults/{election}/{race}`, and each table also exports to Excel (Dane County API [14]). The election and race codes used in this paper are listed below.

Election	ID	MCPASD question	Waunakee questions	Partisan races	Other races used
Nov. 3, 2020	124	none	0045 operating	President 0004	
Nov. 8, 2022	145	0042	0050 bonds, 0051 operating	Governor 0004, AG 0005, Treasurer 0007, U.S. Senate 0008	Ballots cast 0002; county advisory questions 0033–0035 (0035 = abortion);

Election	ID	MCPASD question	Waunakee questions	Partisan races	Other races used
					City of Middleton levy question 0040
Nov. 5, 2024	172	none	0051 operating	President 0004	
Nov. 3, 2026	197	0040	0041 operating, 0042 bonds	Governor 0004, AG 0005, Treasurer 0007	Ballots cast 0002; statewide constitutional questions 0034–0036

Sources: Dane County 2022 [1]; Dane County 2026 [3]; Waunakee precinct tables [16], [17].

Two features of the feed shape the analysis. First, "ballots cast" (race 0002) counts every ballot in a reporting unit, including voters who live in another school district, so whole-unit turnout is not MCPASD turnout in split units. Second, under-votes and over-votes are published only in a fixed-width raw results file, and only for the current election (Dane County raw results file [13]). That file shows **1,834 under-votes and 5 over-votes** on the MCPASD question in 2026, and its Yes and No counts match the Excel exports exactly for every unit. Because the county does not offer the raw file for past elections, 2022 roll-off can be estimated only as ballots cast minus Yes and No, and only in units wholly inside the district.

2.3 Matching wards across the post-2024 ward changes

MCPASD votes came from the same eight municipalities in both years, from 28 reporting units in 2022 and 29 in 2026 (Dane County 2022 [2]; Dane County 2026 [4]). Units changed in four of them. The City of Middleton merged Wards 21 and 22 into neighboring units and added Ward 24. The Town of Middleton went from one unit (Wards 1–8) to four (1, 3–4; 2, 4A; 5–8; and 8A, which had no ballots). The Village of Cross Plains added Ward 7. In Madison, Wards 113, 139, 140 and 141 dropped off the list, Wards 120, 134 and 135 appeared, and Ward 118's ballots grew from 798 to 1,264. Every 2026 split falls exactly on an assembly-district line (What's on the Ballot [15]), which points to the legislative maps first used in 2024, though no municipal ward ordinance was checked.

Comparisons are therefore made at matched comparison units. City Wards 5–8 plus Ward 21 in 2022 are compared with 2026's combined 5–8/21 unit. City Wards 9–13/19 plus Ward 22 are compared with 2026's 9–13/19/22/24, so the 2026 figure includes the new Ward 24. The Town of Middleton is compared only as a whole, the Village with and without Ward 7, and Madison mainly as an aggregate, with its west-side wards combined (118 plus 139/140/141 in 2022; 118 plus 120/134/135 in 2026) to hold geography constant. A unit counts as fully inside the district

when its 2026 ballots cast equal Yes plus No plus under- and over-votes. That status is assumed to hold in 2022 for units with the same definition.

2.4 Partisan baselines and split units

The partisan baseline is the Democratic two-party share, D ÷ (D + R), in the governor's race (Evers–Michels in 2022, Crowley–Tiffany in 2026), with the attorney-general race as a check. AG is the cleanest year-over-year measure, because Josh Kaul and Eric Toney faced each other in both years, while the governor's race moved from a strong incumbent to a first-time nominee (Dane County AG 2022 [9]; AG 2026 [10]). Area aggregates weight each unit's partisan share by its referendum votes.

The main limitation is split units. The governor count covers the whole reporting unit, while the referendum count covers only its MCPASD slice. A unit is flagged as split when its referendum votes are under 85% of its ballots cast. The flag covers all four rural towns, where MCPASD's share of ballots runs from about 8% in Westport to about 72% in Springfield; most Madison wards, where it runs from 2% to 37%; and City of Middleton Wards 14–18. Non-split units carry **73% of 2022 and 76% of 2026 referendum votes**. Unit-level regressions of Yes share on Democratic share are weighted by referendum votes and restricted to units with at least 20 votes (24 units each year), with a non-split subset of 11 units in 2022 and 10 in 2026. Uncertainty in the slope comes from 4,000 bootstrap resamples of units.

2.5 Ecological inference: what ward data can and cannot say

Every partisan finding here relates ward aggregates to ward aggregates. None of it observes an individual ballot. Two tools translate aggregates into statements about voters, and both carry assumptions. The **method of bounds** asks what the aggregates require in the most favorable case. If every Republican voted No, all Yes votes came from Democrats, and the shortfall between the Yes share and the Democratic share becomes a *minimum* Democratic No rate. **Goodman ecological regression** fits Yes share against Democratic share across units and reads the fitted values at 0% and 100% Democratic as party-specific Yes rates. It assumes those rates are constant across wards, an assumption that fails if, for example, City Democrats and Town Democrats behave differently. With 10 to 24 units, Goodman estimates are illustrative only. Neither tool can separate 2022 Yes voters who switched to No from new voters who voted No or from 2022 Yes voters who skipped the question in 2026. The defection figures in this paper are bounds and model estimates, not observations. Appendix B spells out what "Democrat" and "Republican" mean in this paper and tests how ticket-splitting voters would change the defection figures.

2.6 Derived calculations

Several quantities are computed rather than published; all arithmetic was done in Python on the cited figures. Yes share is Yes ÷ (Yes + No). Roll-off is under-votes plus over-votes divided by ballots carrying the question in 2026, and ballots cast minus Yes and No divided by ballots cast in 2022 (fully-inside units only). A referendum's cost per $100,000 is the authority divided by TID-out equalized value, times 100,000. A typical home's gross school tax, before state credits, is its value times the DPI equalized rate, using either Zillow's January value or a 2023 value indexed by DOR's municipal economic change. A school rate printed per $1,000 of

assessed value converts to a rate per $1,000 of market value when multiplied by the municipality's assessment ratio. The jump in an assessment notice caused by a revaluation is approximated as the new ratio divided by the old ratio, times appreciation. Associations between municipal value or tax growth and vote change use the eight municipalities, unweighted, with Pearson and Spearman coefficients. With eight data points, these describe patterns; they do not test hypotheses.

3. Results: a bigger ask lost 2.8 points while the state's pass rate fell 22

The two questions shared a legal form, a purpose clause and a four-year term. They differed in shape. The 2022 authority ramped up from zero to $24.9M; the 2026 authority started at that plateau and climbed from there.

	Nov. 8, 2022	Nov. 3, 2026
Type	Non-recurring, four years	Non-recurring, four years
Annual authority	$7.345M, $13.79M, $19.435M, $24.9M (2023-24 to 2026-27)	$24.9M, $27.9M, $31.1M, $34.6M (2027-28 to 2030-31)
Four-year total	$65.47M	$118.5M
Average per year	about $16.4M	about $29.6M
Final-year ceiling	$24.9M	$34.6M (+39%)
New money above the prior level	all of it	about $18.9M ($3.0M, $6.2M, $9.7M in years 2–4)
District's headline size	"$24.9 million"	"$34.6M," framed as continuing $24.9M
Press headline size	"$65.5 million"	"$118M" or "$118.5 million"
District tax claim per $100K	$7, $53, $39, $36 (yearly steps, "assessed value")	$0, $21, $40, $59 (levels above today's bill, "fair market value"), after an August set of $44, $65, $64, $64
Result	14,596 Yes / 8,608 No, **62.9%** (official)	14,263 Yes / 9,457 No, **60.1%** (unofficial)
Yes margin	5,988	4,806
Other questions on the same ballot	City of Middleton levy referendum; three county advisory questions	Three statewide constitutional amendments
Wisconsin November school pass rate	about 79% (64 of 81)	about 57% (45 of 79, unofficial)

Sources: Dane County 2022 [2]; Dane County 2026 [4]; MCPASD 2022 presentation [31]; Channel 3000, Nov. 9, 2022 [55]; WKOW, Nov. 4, 2026 [52]; WMTV, Nov. 4, 2026 [53]; Civic Media [47]; WPF via WNA [78]; WEAU [74].

The renewal label was accurate in dollars and misleading in shape. Four years at the existing $24.9M account for **$99.6M of the $118.5M (84%)**, so only about **$18.9M** is new money above the current level. The district said the proposal "would continue funding authorized under the district's 2022 operational referendum while adding annual adjustments to address rising costs" (Channel 3000, Aug. 12, 2026 [44]). But the authority grows 12.0%, 11.5% and 11.3% a year, not the "about 3% each year" the Wisconsin Examiner reported; by derived arithmetic, 3% matches the roughly $3M annual increments as a share of a $101M levy (Wisconsin Examiner via Civic Media [47]). The final-year ceiling sits **39% above 2022's**. The Wisconsin Policy Forum ranked the measure the **seventh-largest operating referendum proposed in state history** (Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49]). It was the second-largest operating ask on the November ballot, behind Green Bay's $158M and ahead of Janesville's $98M, and all three were non-recurring (WPR preview [75]). Board president Bob Hesselbein said the board weighed "about six different referendum scenarios" and "didn't want to ask for more because everyone's hurting" (Civic Media [47]), while conceding that "we initially hoped to ask for a higher request" (WMTV, Oct. 22 [50]).

Measured against the state, MCPASD held. Wisconsin voters approved **45 of 79** school questions on Nov. 3, about 57% in unofficial returns (WEAU [74]; Civic Media [73]), compared with **64 of 81 (79%)** in November 2022 (WPF via WNA [78]) and 46 of 75 (61.3%) in April 2026 (WPR, April 2026 [88]). Wisconsin Watch put the spring rate below the 70% average of 2020 to 2025 (Wisconsin Watch [80]), and the Policy Forum had already called 2024's 70.1% approval rate the lowest in a midterm or presidential year since 2014 (WPF via WNA [79]). November 2026 thus ran *below* the spring, the reverse of the usual pattern. Only **3 of 8 recurring operating questions** passed, while limited-term operating questions in larger cities and suburbs, MCPASD among them, did better (Civic Media [73]). Green Bay's renewal squeaked through at about 51% in early returns (WBAY [76]). Elmbrook's $100M capital question passed 61–39, and Whitefish Bay's $90M question won 63%, which FOX6 called the widest school-funding margin in southeast Wisconsin (FOX6 [77]). MCPASD's 60.1% belongs in that top tier.

The district's own trend is the concern. Support has gone from 69% to 63% to 60% across three cycles, each a larger ask, in a state where the Policy Forum's Sara Shaw says "run-of-the-mill districts are going to referendum very frequently," and where pass rates have fallen from about 90% in 2018 to about 60% in spring 2026 (Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49]).

4. Results: No votes rose in Democratic strongholds while the Town of Middleton held

Yes share fell in seven of the eight municipalities. The **849 net new No votes** came almost entirely from four places, and the rural towns together cast slightly *fewer* No votes than in 2022.

Municipality (MCPASD portion)	Yes 2022	No 2022	Yes % 2022	Yes 2026	No 2026	Yes % 2026	Change (pts)	Change in Yes	Change in No
City of Middleton	7,480	3,684	67.0	7,200	3,945	64.6	−2.4	−280	**+261**
City of Madison wards	2,789	1,234	69.3	2,619	1,494	63.7	**−5.6**	−170	**+260**
Town of Middleton	2,134	1,552	57.9	2,320	1,691	57.8	−0.1	+186	+139
Village of Cross Plains	1,177	929	55.9	1,241	1,132	52.3	−3.6	+64	**+203**
Town of Springfield	544	643	45.8	476	632	**43.0**	−2.8	−68	−11
Town of Cross Plains	218	213	50.6	185	212	**46.6**	−4.0	−33	−1
Town of Berry	126	240	34.4	101	248	**28.9**	−5.5	−25	+8
Town of Westport	128	113	53.1	121	103	54.0	+0.9	−7	−10
District	**14,596**	**8,608**	**62.9**	**14,263**	**9,457**	**60.1**	**−2.8**	**−333**	**+849**

Sources: Dane County 2022 [2]; Dane County 2026 [4].

The City of Middleton and the Madison wards each supplied about 31% of the net new No votes, the Village about 24% and the Town of Middleton about 16%; the four rural towns netted −14. On the Yes side, the City (−280) and Madison (−170) accounted for the losses, partly offset by gains in the growing Town of Middleton (+186) and the Village (+64). Three municipalities voted No in 2026: the Town of Berry (28.9%), the Town of Springfield (43.0%) and the MCPASD slice of the Town of Cross Plains (46.6%), which flipped from a narrow 50.6% Yes in 2022. Together they cast only **1,854 votes, 7.8% of the district total**, and their Yes shares fell because Yes votes disappeared (−126 combined) while their No votes were flat (−4). They did not get angrier. They got quieter on Yes.

The comparison units sharpen the picture inside the larger municipalities.

Comparison unit	Ref votes 2026	Yes % 2022	Yes % 2026	Change (pts)	Change in Yes	Change in No	Note
City of Middleton Wds 1–4	3,107	69.0	67.7	−1.3	−50	+37	
City of Middleton Wds 5–8 (+21)	2,596	67.1	**62.5**	**−4.6**	−99	**+132**	Largest City slide
City of Middleton Wds 9–13, 19 (+22, +24)	3,180	66.9	64.7	−2.2	+46	**+125**	Includes new Ward 24
City of Middleton Wds 14–18	2,262	64.4	62.6	−1.8	−177	−33	Partly outside MCPASD; roll-off 10.1%
Town of Middleton (all wards)	4,011	57.9	57.8	−0.1	+186	+139	One unit became four
Village	2,266	55.9	**51.8**	−4.1	−4	**+164**	Ballots

Comparison unit	Ref votes 2026	Yes % 2022	Yes % 2026	Change (pts)	Change in Yes	Change in No	Note
of Cross Plains Wds 1–6							2,252 → 2,340
Village of Cross Plains Wd 7	107	new	63.6	—	+68	+39	New ward
Madison west side combined (118 + 139/140/141 → 118 + 120/134/135)	1,258	71.8	68.0	−3.7	+132	+117	Renumbering-neutral
Madison Wd 119	1,447	66.1	61.4	−4.7	−104	+48	

Source: computed from Dane County 2022 [2] and 2026 [4] precinct tables.

Each place lost ground in a different way. The **Village of Cross Plains core (Wards 1–6)** is the clearest case of lost persuasion: on almost the same number of ballots, Yes was flat (−4) while No rose by 164, so the additional and changed votes broke almost entirely No, and the core now sits at a near-even **51.8%**. The new Ward 7 voted 63.6% Yes on 107 votes, well above the core. In the **City of Middleton**, losses concentrated in Wards 5–8/21, which fell 4.6 points with 132 new No votes, and in Wards 9–13/19/22/24, where growth around the new Ward 24 added mostly No votes. City Wards 14–18 behaved differently: Yes fell 177 votes while No *also* fell 33, so that unit lost votes to the blank line rather than to the other side. The **Town of Middleton** added 325 referendum votes (+8.8%) on a 14% rise in ballots, and the new voters split almost exactly as the existing ones did.

The Madison wards need care. Individual split wards show dramatic drops—Ward 102 fell 16.0 points, Ward 100 16.6 and Ward 109 11.7—but those wards lie mostly outside MCPASD and cast only a few hundred district votes each. The renumbering also complicates single-ward comparisons. Combining the west-side wards to hold geography constant gives a cleaner but still meaningful figure: **71.8% to 68.0% (−3.7 points)**. The split Madison wards taken together fell from 70.9% to 62.2%. Whatever happened there, it was not a product of renumbering alone.

5. Results: the extra voters broke No, and Middleton ballots went blank

Turnout rose modestly, and the additional voters did not help Yes. Referendum votes rose **2.2%** (23,204 to 23,720), while Dane County ballots rose 3.5% (302,575 to 313,218). Ballots cast in units fully inside the district rose **7.7%** (13,759 to 14,822), and in the Town of Middleton they rose **14.1%** (3,823 to 4,363) (Dane County ballots cast 2022 [5]; 2026 [6]). Applying the roughly 5% roll-off observed in comparable 2022 geography, by derived estimate about 24,400–24,500 ballots carried the question in 2022, against 25,559 in 2026, an increase of 4–5%.

In 2026, **1,839 of the 25,559 ballots** that carried the MCPASD question recorded no valid vote on it, a roll-off rate of **7.2%** (Dane County raw results file [13]). The **City of Middleton alone produced 1,090 of them (59%)**, an 8.9% rate on 48% of the district's ballots. Rates elsewhere were 7.5% in the Town of Cross Plains, 7.2% in the Town of Middleton, 5.2% in the Madison wards, 5.0% in Springfield, 3.3% in Berry, 3.2% in the Village of Cross Plains and 12.8% on just 257 ballots in Westport. The year-over-year change can be measured only where units sit wholly inside the district.

Units fully inside MCPASD	Ballots 2022 → 2026	MCPASD roll-off 2022 (est.)	MCPASD roll-off 2026	2026 statewide questions, same ballots	Governor roll-off 2026
City of Middleton (Wds 1–4, 5–8/21, 9–13/19/22/24)	9,146 → 9,720	5.0%	**8.6%**	3.1–3.7%	0.7%
Town of Middleton (all wards)	3,823 → 4,363	3.6%	**8.1%** (7.2% direct count)	2.5–3.1%	0.6%
Village of Cross Plains Wds 1–6	2,252 → 2,340	6.5%	**3.2%**	2.9–3.1%	0.3%
Madison Wds 118–119	2,361 → 2,762	4.9%	**3.5%**	2.5–3.0%	0.4%
All four combined	17,582 → 19,185	4.8%	7.1%		

Sources: Dane County ballots cast 2022 [5] and 2026 [6]; governor 2022 [7] and 2026 [8]; 2026 statewide questions [11]; 2022 county and City questions [12]. Town of Middleton figures are ballots minus Yes and No, which includes about 43 ballots without the question in Wards 5–8.

This is not a uniform "voters missed the back of the ballot" story, although NBC15 did report that the question "will appear on the back of the ballot" (WMTV, Oct. 22 [50]). Roll-off *fell* in the Village and in Madison Wards 118–119 while it nearly doubled in the City and Town of Middleton. In those two Middleton municipalities the school question drew **2.3 to 2.8 times** the roll-off of the three statewide constitutional questions printed on the same ballots, while in the Village and Madison it ran level with them. Some of the rise is ballot-wide: roll-off on the 2026 statewide questions (2.5–3.7%) ran about double that on 2022's county advisory questions (1.0–2.2%). In 2022 the City's own first operating levy referendum, which added $770,000 for police officers and other staff and passed by at least 12 points (Channel 3000, Sept. 27, 2022 [58]; WPF via WNA [78]), had 5.1% roll-off in the same City units, nearly identical to the school question's 5.0%. That suggests both local questions sat late on City ballots that year. The municipal pattern points to a ballot-layout difference, such as which side or column the school question occupied in each ballot style. No ballot style was inspected, so this remains a hypothesis. The risk is real elsewhere: WPR reported that the Herman-Neosho-Rubicon district's April 2024 referendum, printed last and on the back of the ballot in two of its largest communities, failed, with placement offered as a possible explanation (secondhand detail; WPR, April 2024 [87]).

Skipping was *highest in the most Democratic places*. Across 21 units with at least 50 ballots, the weighted correlation between the under-vote rate and the Republican governor share was **−0.47**. Measured only in non-split units, as ballots minus votes, the correlation was a weaker −0.21 in 2022 and −0.35 in 2026, but it pointed the same way both years (Dane County 2026 [4]). The data offer no support for a story in which Republican-leaning wards ignored the question. They are consistent with conflicted Democrats leaving it blank, though aggregates cannot show who skipped.

The new voters broke badly for Yes. In the clean geography (the Town of Middleton, the Village, the City of Middleton excluding Wards 14–18, and Madison's whole wards), ballots rose by **1,492**. About 12% of them became Yes votes (+175), **54% became No votes (+801)** and 35% skipped the question (+516) (Dane County 2022 [1]; 2026 [3]). Roll-off did not threaten passage. Had the City and Town of Middleton kept their 2022 roll-off rates, roughly **550 more votes** would have been cast; at those areas' 58–65% Yes rates, that would have added only about 100–150 to the Yes margin.

Waunakee offers a natural comparison, because three reporting units carried both districts' questions on different ballot styles. In each of them, the Waunakee question had lower roll-off than the MCPASD question: **6.8% against 12.8%** in Westport, **6.6% against 10.1%** in City of Middleton Wards 14–18, and 3.8% against 5.0% in Springfield (Dane County raw results file [13]). Waunakee's mailed newsletter and its paid Tribune information piece both told voters "Make Sure to Flip the Ballot!" (Waunakee newsletter [37]; Waunakee Tribune piece [39]). By the MCPASD Yes campaign's internal and unverified record, it asked six municipal clerks for a neutral "check both sides" reminder and only the City of Madison agreed (Referendum canvass volunteer plan [43]). Madison Wards 118–119 were among the units where roll-off fell. That is suggestive rather than conclusive, because the Village's roll-off also fell without any known reminder.

6. Results: Yes ran 17 points behind the Democrats, and the gap grew

6.1 Party still sorts the wards, but less tightly

Partisanship still predicts where Yes is strong. Across the 24 reporting units with at least 20 referendum votes, Yes share tracked the Democratic governor share with a weighted correlation of **0.88 in 2022 and 0.79 in 2026**. The relationship became weaker and flatter under every partisan measure tested.

Sample (weighted by referendum votes)	Partisan measure	2022 r / slope	2026 r / slope
All units, n = 24	Governor	0.879 / 0.81	0.793 / 0.69
All units	Attorney general (Kaul–Toney both years)	0.875 / 0.80	0.796 / 0.72
All units	Treasurer	0.863 / 0.74	0.771 / 0.64
All units	2022 U.S. Senate (Barnes)	0.882 / 0.77	n/a
Non-split units, n = 11 / 10	Governor	0.842 / 0.68	0.705 / 0.51
Non-split units	Attorney general	0.825 / 0.65	0.705 / 0.53

Source: computed from Dane County governor 2022 [7] and 2026 [8], AG [9], [10], and the MCPASD precinct tables.

Yes rose 0.81 points per Democratic point in 2022 and 0.69 in 2026 across all units, and 0.68 to 0.51 within units wholly inside the district. With so few units the change is directional, not conclusive. The bootstrap puts the all-unit slope at 0.81 (90% interval 0.66–1.03) in 2022 and 0.69 (0.44–0.92) in 2026; the change of −0.12 has a 90% interval of −0.46 to +0.16, and **77% of resamples show a flatter 2026 slope** (70% for non-split units). The referendum became *less* partisan, because it lost ground in heavily Democratic territory while holding in the less Democratic Town of Middleton. The same compression shows up in ideological questions on the ballot. In 2022, the Dane County advisory question on repealing the abortion ban correlated with school Yes at r = 0.87 across all units (Dane County 2022 advisory questions [12]). In 2026, the share voting No on the three Republican-sponsored constitutional amendments correlated with school Yes at only 0.63 to 0.80.

6.2 The gap between Yes and the Democratic vote widened in seven of eight places

District-wide, Yes ran **13.7 points behind Evers in 2022 and 17.1 points behind Crowley in 2026**. The attorney-general rematch gives the cleanest test. On that measure the MCPASD electorate became *more* Democratic, with Kaul's two-party share rising from **74.3% to 77.5%**, and the gap still widened from **−11.4 to −17.4** (Dane County AG 2022 [9]; 2026 [10]).

Area	Dem governor % 2022	Dem governor % 2026	Yes minus Dem, 2022	Yes minus Dem, 2026	Change in gap	Ref votes from split units, 2026
Town of Middleton	68.3	68.9	−10.4	−11.0	**−0.6 (held)**	0%
Town of Westport (part)	65.6	65.4	−12.5	−11.4	+1.1 (small n)	100%
City of Middleton	83.1	84.3	−16.1	−19.7	−3.6	20%
Village of Cross Plains	71.1	70.7	−15.2	−18.4	−3.2	0%
Town of Springfield (part)	56.5	56.7	−10.7	−13.7	−3.0	100%
Town of Berry (part)	59.6	57.6	−25.2	−28.7	−3.5	100%
Town of Cross Plains (part)	59.3	59.6	−8.7	−13.0	−4.3	100%
City of Madison wards	78.9	79.7	−9.5	−16.0	**−6.5**	35%
District	**76.6**	**77.3**	**−13.7**	**−17.1**	**−3.4**	**24%**

Source: computed from Dane County precinct files (2022 [2], 2026 [4]). For split towns and Madison wards, the partisan share describes the whole reporting unit, not only its MCPASD slice.

The **Town of Middleton held**. Its Yes share was flat while its Democratic share edged up, and Wards 5–8 ran **6.7 points ahead** of what the district-wide partisan fit predicts, at 59.5% Yes in a unit that went 66.6% for Crowley. Madison Ward 118 (+7.2) and City of Middleton Wards 1–4 (+3.1) also beat their partisan predictions. The gap grew most in the Madison split wards, from −10.8 to −21.9, and in **City of Middleton Wards 5–8/21**, which went 86.7% for Crowley but only 62.5% Yes. That −24.2 gap is the widest of any large unit wholly inside the district. The Town of Berry is the district's largest outlier in both years, at 28.9% Yes in a unit that went 57.6% for Crowley, but its MCPASD voters may lean more Republican than the town as a whole.

In no unit with 20 or more votes, in either year, did Yes exceed the Democratic share; the closest were Village Ward 7 in 2026 (−3.1) and Madison Ward 117 in 2022 (−2.4).

6.3 At least one in five Crowley voters voted No

The Democratic wave raised turnout without raising Yes. In the clean geography, Crowley ran **1,265 votes ahead of Evers (+9.2%)** and Tiffany gained **266 votes** on Michels. Yes rose 175 votes while No rose 801, three times the Republican gain.

Clean geography	Ballots	Dem governor votes	Rep governor votes	Yes	No	Yes %	Dem two-party %
2022 (Evers–Michels)	17,853	13,780	3,884	10,916	6,080	64.2	78.0
2026 (Crowley–Tiffany)	19,345	15,045	4,150	11,091	6,881	61.7	78.4
Change	+1,492	+1,265	+266	+175	+801	−2.5	+0.4

Source: computed from Dane County governor 2022 [7] and 2026 [8] and the referendum tables.

Yes votes fell from **79.2% of the Democratic governor vote to 73.7%** in that geography, a crude measure that includes roll-off. Because Yes never exceeded the Democratic share in any sizable unit, the data require *zero* Republican crossover. The method of bounds then sets a floor on Democratic defection. If every Republican-voting participant voted No, at least **17.9% of Democratic-voting participants voted No in 2022 and at least 22.3% in 2026**; in City Wards 5–8/21 the 2026 floor is 27.9%. These floors describe Crowley voters, not party members. Republicans or independents who voted for Crowley and then voted No would lower the share of loyal Democrats voting No, but they would not erase its rise since 2022 (Appendix B). A more realistic scenario, in which 15% of Republicans voted Yes, puts the Democratic No rate at about **27%**. A Goodman fit on non-split units points the same way, with Democratic Yes falling from about 79% to about 73%, while Republican Yes may have risen from about 11% to about 22%; with ten units, that second estimate is not reliable.

Cross-pressure is visible elsewhere on the 2026 ballot. The three Republican-sponsored constitutional amendments drew **28–39% Yes** in MCPASD's non-split units, well above Tiffany's roughly 21.6%. One of them limits the governor's partial veto from creating or raising taxes, a response to Evers's "400-year" school-revenue veto; it took 32.5% Yes in those units and was ratified statewide (Dane County State Question 1 [11]; Wikipedia, 2026 Wisconsin elections [94]).

6.4 MCPASD had Dane County's widest gap in 2022, and it grew

Year	Dane County school question	Yes %	Est. Dem %	Gap
2022	**MCPASD (revenue limit)**	62.9	76.6	**−13.7**
2022	Waunakee #1 (bonds, $175M)	52.6	65.9	−13.2
2022	Oregon (revenue limit)	60.6	73.4	−12.8
2022	Sun Prairie (revenue limit)	60.5	71.7	−11.2
2022	Verona (revenue limit)	69.9	77.2	−7.3
2022	Belleville (revenue limit)	62.4	69.5	−7.0
2022	Stoughton #2 / #1 (bonds)	62.6 / 65.7	69.2	−6.6 / −3.4
2022	Waunakee #2 (revenue limit)	60.3	65.9	−5.6
2022	Mount Horeb (revenue limit)	65.1	68.6	−3.4
2022	Waterloo (revenue limit)	51.7	50.5	+1.2
2026	**MCPASD (revenue limit)**	60.1	77.3	**−17.1**
2026	Waunakee Q1 (revenue limit) / Q2 (bonds, $97.5M)	52.6 / 51.7	66.5	−13.9 / −14.9
2026	Lodi Q1 (revenue	51.7 / 46.8	48.9	+2.8 / −2.1

Year	Dane County school question	Yes %	Est. Dem %	Gap
	limit) / Q2 (bonds)			

Source: computed from the Dane County-portion results of each question (Dane County 2022 [1]; 2026 [3]), with the governor's two-party share weighted by referendum votes.

The statewide literature anticipates this compression. In November 2022, local referendum support outran Evers's county share in **61 of 81** school measures; of the 20 where Evers ran ahead, 12 were in Dane or Milwaukee counties (Cap Times, Nov. 24, 2022 [81]). School Perceptions' Rob DeMeuse told the Cap Times that party affiliation was "not 'activated'" in referendums, although his model still moved predicted approval from above 90% to about 52% as a district's Republican presidential share went from 0% to 100% (Cap Times, Nov. 24, 2022 [81]). Polling, by contrast, now shows school-funding attitudes splitting roughly 80/20 by party: 79% of Democrats but 18% of Republicans said the Legislature had failed to provide enough funding, rather than that schools must live within their budgets (Marquette Law School Poll, Feb. 2026 [82]). The best way to reconcile the two is that the statewide turn against school tax referendums reached Democratic suburban homeowners through their tax bills and the size of the ask, without deepening the party split. A school question in a 77% Democratic district loses its marginal voters on the Democratic side.

7. Results: property values and school taxes explain the Village and the small towns, not the City

7.1 District-wide, the school rate fell 13% while the levy rose 27%

The tax record that voters carried into 2026 is a paradox that both sides could quote truthfully. DPI data show MCPASD's TID-out equalized value rising far faster than its levy, so the mill rate fell even as tax bills grew.

School year	Levy	Equalized value (TID-out)	Mill rate	Levy change	Value change
2020-21	$79.7M	$7.60B	10.49		
2021-22	$79.6M	$8.00B	9.95	−0.2%	+5.2%
2022-23	$81.5M	$9.17B	8.89	+2.4%	+14.7%
2023-24	$84.1M	$10.00B	8.41	+3.1%	+9.0%
2024-25	$91.2M	$10.96B	8.32	+8.4%	+9.6%
2025-26	$101.2M	$11.73B	8.62	+11.0%	+7.0%
2026 tax year (2026-27)	not yet posted	**$13.06B** (DOR)	not yet posted		+11.3%

Sources: DPI equalized tax rates, FY2020-21 to FY2026-27 [19]; DOR 2026 school certification [20]. DPI's FY2026-27 page held no district rows on Nov. 5, 2026.

From 2021-22 to 2025-26, the levy rose **27.1%** while the rate fell **13.4%**, because equalized value rose **46.6%**. The municipal rate sheets confirm DPI's rate: in 2025 the City of Middleton's printed school rate of 0.011059 per assessed dollar at a 0.7827 ratio and the Town of Middleton's 0.008928 at 0.9659 both convert to about 8.62–8.66 per $1,000 of market value (Dane County Treasurer [25]). By derived arithmetic, a home worth $400,000 in 2021-22 whose value tracked district-wide growth paid about **$3,980** in gross school tax that year and about **$5,055** in 2025-26, a 27% rise. Because district value growth includes new construction, a typical existing home appreciated somewhat less and saw a smaller increase. Two further facts frame the backdrop. The levy jumped 8.4% and then 11.0% in the two years *before* this vote, coinciding with the 2022 referendum's year-3 step, the state's $325-per-pupil revenue-limit increases without new general aid, and slower value growth. And levy growth from 2022-23 to 2025-26 (+$19.6M) almost exactly equals that year's referendum authority ($19.435M), a figure any future opponent can quote.

The state backdrop explains why the levy, not state aid, absorbed rising costs. The 2022 ask followed two straight years of $0 per-pupil revenue-limit increases and 4.7% inflation, plus $6.9M in one-time COVID money that the district warned would create "a significant fiscal cliff" (MCPASD 2022 presentation [31]). By 2026, districts were receiving $325 per pupil a year, which Evers's partial veto extended through 2425 and the state Supreme Court upheld in April 2025 (Wisconsin Examiner, Apr. 18, 2025 [89]). The 2025-27 budget added no general aid, so that increase falls on local property taxes (WSAA [91]; DPI Act 15 summary [92]), and special-education reimbursement, budgeted at 42% for 2025-26 (WEAC [93]), came in at a 35% interim rate (Wisconsin Examiner, Nov. 21, 2025 [90]). That matters more in MCPASD than in most districts, because its leaders describe it as about **80% property-tax funded** and "one of the highest in Dane County for property values to students" (Civic Media [47]; WKOW, Aug. 12 [46]).

7.2 Values rose 42% since 2022, but half of the last year's jump was a closed TID

MCPASD's TID-out equalized value rose **42.4%**, from $9.17B for 2022 to **$13.06B for 2026** (DPI FY2022-23 [19]; DOR 2026 [20]). The MCPASD portions of the municipalities grew at very different rates.

Municipality (MCPASD portion)	2024	2025	2026	2024→2026	2025→2026	Share of district, 2025 → 2026
City of Middleton	$4,477.5M	$4,617.0M	$5,568.7M	**+24.4%**	+20.6%	39.36% → **42.64%**
City of Madison	$2,532.3M	$2,772.4M	$2,871.3M	+13.4%	+3.6%	23.64% → 21.98%

Municipality (MCPASD portion)	2024	2025	2026	2024→2026	2025→2026	Share of district, 2025 → 2026
Town of Middleton	$2,149.4M	$2,293.9M	$2,521.8M	+17.3%	+9.9%	19.56% → 19.31%
Village of Cross Plains	$563.7M	$639.3M	$685.7M	+21.6%	+7.3%	5.45% → 5.25%
Town of Springfield	$558.7M	$665.7M	$637.0M	+14.0%	**−4.3%**	5.68% → 4.88%
Town of Westport	$326.8M	$350.5M	$384.5M	+17.7%	+9.7%	2.99% → 2.94%
Town of Cross Plains	$189.4M	$213.0M	$222.9M	+17.7%	+4.7%	1.82% → 1.71%
Town of Berry	$162.3M	$177.9M	$168.8M	+4.0%	**−5.1%**	1.52% → 1.29%
District	**$10,960.1M**	**$11,729.7M**	**$13,060.6M**	**+19.2%**	**+11.3%**	100%

Sources: DOR Fall School District Certification of Values, 2024–2026 [20]. The 2024 and 2025 district totals match DPI exactly.

About half of the district's 11.3% jump for 2026 came from a **City of Middleton tax-increment district closing**, not from homes appreciating. The City's MCPASD portion showed a $958.3M gap between TID-in and TID-out value in 2025 and a $304.1M gap in 2026, and DOR's 2026 county apportionment lists only one remaining City TID, No. 005, with a $304.1M increment (DOR 2025 [20]; DOR apportionment [22]). By derived arithmetic, roughly $654M returned to the base, along with about $12M from a closed Springfield TID; excluding both, district value grew about **5.7%**, not 11.3%. A closed TID's value joins the base of every taxing body, so it lowers the school rate for every MCPASD taxpayer, and the City's larger levy share falls mostly on the formerly captured, largely commercial parcels rather than on existing City homes. By derived arithmetic, if the 2026-27 levy had stayed at $101.15M, the equalized rate would fall to about **7.75**; with an 8% levy increase it would be about 8.36. A levy increase of up to about 11% would not raise the rate at all. DOR also *cut* the 2026 values of the Towns of Springfield (−4.3%) and Berry (−5.1%), so their shares of the school levy on December 2026 bills will fall by about 14% and 15%. Those figures were public in August and September, before the vote, but the research found no coverage connecting them to the referendum.

Home appreciation, measured two ways, shows the Village of Cross Plains fastest and the City of Middleton slowest among the large units.

Geography	Zillow typical home, Jan. 2022	Jan. 2026	Change	DOR residential economic change, 2023–2026 (whole municipality)
City of Middleton	$485,044	$610,366	+25.8%	+17.8% (+10%, +3%, +4%)
Village of Cross Plains	$409,626	$504,024	+23.0%	**+28.1%** (+13%, +10%, +3%)
City of Madison (ZIP 53717 for west side)	$398,140 (53717)	$499,591 (53717)	+25.5%	+20.2% (city)
Town of Middleton (ZIP 53562, shared with City)	$489,226	$616,377	+26.0%	+21.3%
Town of Cross Plains (ZIP 53528)	$423,391	$528,408	+24.8%	+25.8%
Town of Springfield (shared ZIPs)	—	—	~+25–30%	+24.7% (+8%, +17.9%, −2%)
Town of Berry (shared ZIPs)	—	—	~+23–25%	+15.5% (+12.7%, +9%, −6%)
Town of Westport (shared ZIPs)	—	—	~+25–26%	+14.5% (0%, +5%, +9%)

Sources: Zillow ZHVI by city and ZIP [30]; DOR Statement of Changes, Dane County, 2024–2026 [21]. Zillow publishes no town series; DOR's single-year town figures rest on few sales and swing widely.

Both sources agree on 20–28% gains since 2022–23 that flattened in 2025–26, with Zillow showing only 2–4% growth from January 2025 to January 2026. Including new construction and other changes, whole-municipality residential equalized value grew from 22.6% (City of Madison) to **38.5% (Village of Cross Plains)** between 2023 and 2026 (DOR Statement of Changes [21]).

7.3 Assessment ratios and revaluations put very different numbers on similar homes

Assessed values, the number printed on a notice, moved on a separate track from market values, because municipalities revalue on their own schedules. By 2025, three municipalities had drifted far below DOR's required band of 90–110% of market: the City of Middleton (0.78), the Village of Cross Plains (**0.65**) and the Town of Berry (0.67) (DOR TVC data, 2023–2025 [23]; DOR PB-060 [24]).

Municipality	Assessment ratio 2023 / 2024 / 2025	Revaluation evidence	Notice jump implied by the ratio change alone (derived)	2025 MCPASD rate printed per $1,000 assessed
City of Middleton	0.89 / 0.80 / 0.78	Citywide revaluation to 100% for 2026; Board of Review Sept. 22, 2026	**+28%** in 2026 (about +33% with appreciation)	11.06
Town of Middleton	0.78 / 0.73 / 0.97	Implied 2025 revaluation; another for 2026, notices mailed week of April 14	+32% in 2025; about +12% in 2026 with appreciation	8.93
Village of Cross Plains	0.81 / 0.72 / **0.65**	None through 2025; 2026 roll valued July 22, Open Book Aug. 3	+53% *if* revalued to 100%	**13.25** (highest)
Town of Springfield	0.63 / 0.58 / 0.94	Implied 2025 revaluation	**+63%** in 2025	8.9–9.2 range of revalued towns
Town of Westport	0.72 / 0.71 / 0.98	Implied 2025 revaluation	+38% in 2025	8.88
Town of Cross Plains	0.66 / 1.01 / 0.93	Implied 2024 revaluation	**+53%** in 2024	8.9–9.2 range of revalued towns
Town of Berry	0.91 / 0.73 / 0.67	None in 2024–2025	+50% *if* revalued to 100%	12.94
City of Madison	0.99 / 0.99 / 0.97	Annual market-level assessment	none	not on county sheet

Sources: DOR TVC data [23]; Dane County Treasurer, 2025 mill rates [25]; City of Middleton Revaluation Overview [26]; Town of Middleton newsletter [29]; AccessDane parcel records [28]. Revaluation years for the towns are inferred from DOR ratio jumps; implied notice jumps are approximate because the 2023–2024 ratios carry only two decimals, and the Town of Middleton's 2026 figure assumes its 2026 ratio is about 1.00.

Every printed school rate in the table, from 8.88 to 13.25 per $1,000 of assessed value, converts to **8.58–8.70 per $1,000 of market value** once multiplied by its ratio, which matches DPI's 8.62 district rate. Wisconsin apportions the school levy among municipalities by DOR's equalized value, "since the assessed values are not comparable among municipalities, whereas the equalized values are all at market value" (DOR PB-060 [24]). A revaluation therefore cannot change a municipality's share of the school levy. It changes the assessed number on the notice and the rate printed on the bill, and it shifts tax *within* the municipality toward properties that had been under-assessed.

7.4 Tax growth tracks where Yes slipped, not where the No votes came from

Municipality (MCPASD part)	2026 Yes %	Change in Yes (pts)	Change in No votes	DOR home appreciation 2023–26	Municipality's MCPASD school tax, 2024–2025 bills	Typical-home school tax 2023–2025 (DOR index)	Ratio 2025 / revaluation
City of Middleton	64.6	−2.4	**+261 (+7.1%)**	+17.8%	**+6.9%** (slowest)	+16.2%	0.78 → 100% for 2026
City of Madison wards	63.7	**−5.6**	**+260 (+21.1%)**	+20.2%	+13.5%	+18.5%	0.97, annual
Town of Middleton	57.8	−0.1	+139 (+9.0%)	+21.3%	+10.7%	+15.2%	0.97; revalued 2025 and 2026
Village of Cross Plains	52.3	−3.6	**+203 (+21.9%)**	**+28.1%**	+17.6%	**+27.5%**	**0.65**; none through 2025

Municipality (MCPASD part)	2026 Yes %	Change in Yes (pts)	Change in No votes	DOR home appreciation 2023–26	Municipality's MCPASD school tax, 2024→2025 bills	Typical-home school tax 2023→2025 (DOR index)	Ratio 2025 / revaluation
Town of Springfield	**43.0**	−2.8	−11 (−1.7%)	+24.7%	**+23.5%**	**+30.5%**	0.94; revalued 2025
Town of Cross Plains	**46.6**	−4.0	−1 (−0.5%)	+25.8%	+16.6%	+24.0%	0.93; revalued 2024
Town of Berry	**28.9**	−5.5	+8 (+3.3%)	+15.5%	+13.6%	+26.0%	0.67; none
Town of Westport	54.0	+0.9	−10 (−8.8%)	+14.5%	+11.2%	+7.7%	0.98; revalued 2025
District	**60.1**	**−2.8**	**+849 (+9.9%)**		**+11.0%** (levy)		

Sources: vote changes from Dane County [2], [4]; school tax by municipality from DOR TVC 2024 and 2025 [23]; appreciation from DOR Statement of Changes [21]. The typical-home column applies DOR's 2024 and 2025 economic change to the ratio of the 2025 and 2023 district rates (derived).

Measured instead with Zillow's January values at the district rate, a typical home's gross school tax rose by about **$580–$860 (16–20%)** between the 2022 bill and the 2025 bill, which was the last bill voters saw before Nov. 3: from $4,310 to $5,148 in the City of Middleton (+$838), $4,347 to $5,201 in ZIP 53562, $3,538 to $4,214 in west Madison's ZIP 53717, $3,762 to $4,394 in ZIP 53528, and $3,640 to $4,224 in the Village of Cross Plains (+$584) (derived from Zillow [30] and DPI [19]).

Measure (8 municipalities, unweighted)	vs. change in Yes pts	vs. % change in No votes	vs. 2026 Yes %
Typical-home school tax 2023→25 (DOR	**−0.66** (Spearman −0.55)	+0.23 (+0.12)	−0.58 (−0.67)

Measure (8 municipalities, unweighted)	vs. change in Yes pts	vs. % change in No votes	vs. 2026 Yes %
index)			
Municipality's MCPASD school tax 2024→25	−0.31 (−0.43)	−0.04 (−0.10)	−0.50 (−0.76)
DOR home appreciation 2023→26	−0.23 (−0.24)	+0.40 (+0.40)	+0.02 (−0.19)
Residential equalized value 2023→26	−0.30 (−0.14)	+0.25 (+0.14)	−0.60 (−0.69)
MCPASD-portion equalized value 2024→26	+0.46 (+0.51)	+0.16 (+0.10)	+0.74 (+0.46)
Zillow Jan. 2022→Jan. 2026 (ZIP proxies)	+0.46 (+0.70)	−0.53 (−0.50)	+0.25 (+0.27)

A negative coefficient in the first column means faster growth went with larger Yes losses. All coefficients are derived.

The answer to RQ4 is therefore **not consistently**. The strongest relationship links a typical home's 2023–25 school-tax growth to the change in Yes points ($r \approx -0.66$), and it rests on the Village and the rural towns, which together cast about 19% of 2026 referendum votes. On the share of new No votes, the relationship is near zero. Most of the 849 new No votes came from the City of Middleton and the Madison wards, where school taxes on a typical home grew at or below the district rate. Value growth is also confounded with rurality and partisanship, since the fastest-growing towns are the most Republican, and Zillow's shared ZIP codes are coarse enough that they correlate in the "wrong" direction.

7.5 The City of Middleton: slowest tax growth, a notice shock mid-campaign

The City cuts against a simple "bigger bills, more No votes" story. Its aggregate MCPASD school tax rose only **6.9%** from the 2024 to the 2025 bills, the slowest in the district, and DOR measured its homes as appreciating least among the large units (+17.8% from 2023 to 2026). Yet it added the most No votes. What the City had that others did not was a revaluation timed into the campaign. The City "contracted with Associated Appraisal Consultants (AAC) to perform a revaluation of all property for the 2026 assessment cycle," with "the purpose... to bring all assessed values to 100% market value" (City of Middleton Revaluation Overview [26]). The City's notice, known only secondhand because the page now returns an error, reported that total assessed value rose about 32% and stated that revaluation "redistributes how the tax levy is shared among properties; it does not, by itself, generate additional tax revenue." Board of Review met Sept. 22, 2026, six weeks before the vote (City of Middleton notice, secondhand [27]); a City parcel on AccessDane carries a 2026 valuation date of Sept. 21 (AccessDane [28]).

A worked example shows how far the notice and the bill diverge. All figures are derived and cover the gross school line only.

$500,000-market City of Middleton home	2025 bill (paid 2026)	2026 notice (summer 2026)	Dec. 2026 bill, levy flat	Dec. 2026 bill, levy +8%
Market value	$500,000	about $520,000 (DOR +4%)	about $520,000	about $520,000
Assessed value	about $391,350 (ratio 0.7827)	about $520,000 (**+33%**)	about $520,000	about $520,000
School rate per $1,000 assessed	11.06	—	about 7.75	about 8.36
Gross school tax	**$4,328**	—	about **$4,027**	about **$4,349**

Sources: Dane County Treasurer [25]; DOR Statement of Changes [21]; DOR 2026 certification [20].

City owners saw notices up about a third, several times their real appreciation, during the weeks the referendum was being argued, while their actual school bill depended on the levy and their home's value relative to the district, not on the notice. DOR's guide says it plainly: "If the total levy remains the same, only those properties that are not presently paying their fair share of the tax burden will pay more taxes after a revaluation" (DOR PB-060 [24]). The Town of Middleton offers the closest contrast. Its 2026 revaluation notices went out in April and, by derived arithmetic, implied only about a 12% change, and the Town held its Yes share (Town of Middleton newsletter [29]). But the Town also absorbed a roughly 32% notice jump in 2025, and Springfield and the Town of Cross Plains absorbed even larger jumps in 2024 and 2025, without adding No votes. The notice-shock hypothesis survives only in its *timing* form: a large notice arriving during the campaign, not a large notice as such. No reporting, survey or letter connects the City's notices to referendum votes.

7.6 The Village of Cross Plains: every measure lines up

The Village is the one place where every tax-related measure points the same way as the vote. It had the fastest residential appreciation in the district (**+28.1%** by DOR's index from 2023 to 2026; +38.5% in residential value including new construction), the second-fastest growth in its aggregate MCPASD school tax (+17.6% from the 2024 to the 2025 bills), and a typical-home school tax up about **27.5%** from the 2023 to the 2025 bills by the DOR index, or about 16% from 2022 to 2025 by Zillow (DOR [21]; DOR TVC [23]). Its assessment ratio fell from 0.81 to 0.65 in two years, so its bills printed the highest school rate in the district, **13.25 per $1,000 of assessed value** against 8.9–9.2 in the revalued towns (Dane County Treasurer [25]). The Village's 2026 roll carried a July 22 valuation date with Open Book starting Aug. 3, 2026, a late schedule that fits a revaluation but does not prove one (AccessDane [28]). If the Village did

revalue from 0.65 to market, its notices would have jumped about 53% for an unchanged home. Its No votes rose 22%, and its core fell to 51.8% Yes, the closest large unit in the district.

7.7 The No-voting towns and the Madison wards

The three towns that voted No did see above-average school-tax growth. Springfield's aggregate MCPASD tax rose **23.5%** in a single year after DOR estimated a 17.9% residential gain and the town revalued; its typical-home school tax rose about 30.5% from 2023 to 2025. The Town of Cross Plains rose 16.6% and Berry 13.6% in that year, with typical-home increases of about 24% and 26% since 2023 (DOR TVC [23]). Springfield's and the Town of Cross Plains's revaluations implied notice jumps of more than 50%, and Berry, never revalued in this period, printed a 12.94 school rate on its bills. Yet those towns added almost no No votes (−11, −1, +8); their Yes shares fell because Yes voters dropped out. DOR then *cut* Springfield's and Berry's 2026 values, so their shares of December 2026 school taxes will fall. On the other side of the district, the Madison wards added nearly as many No votes (+260, +21%) on middling value and tax growth (+20.2% city appreciation; +13.5% MCPASD-portion school tax), with annual market-level assessment and therefore no notice shock. Value and tax growth do not explain Madison well, and ward renumbering and split-unit geography make its decline the hardest to interpret.

8. Results: the district's tax numbers changed size, basis and meaning

8.1 The record, source by source

Voters who followed the coverage could find at least four different "costs" for the 2026 question, on two different bases, with no stated baseline in the first set. The table assembles every figure the research located, in date order, alongside the 2022 claim and Waunakee's same-ballot claim.

Date	Where it appeared	Figures as published	Stated basis	Baseline	Assessment
Aug.–Nov. 2022	District deck, slide 24; Channel 3000; Cap Times ([31]; [55]; [56])	+$7, +$53, +$39, +$36 per $100K in years 1–4	"$100,000 assessed value"	Year-over-year steps (inferred); cumulative $135	Steps in years 2–3 match referendum ÷ equalized value (derived)
Nov. 3, 2022	NBC15 ([57])	"$7, then $53 in year two and around $38 in years three and four"	per $100K	steps	Rounded restatement
Aug. 12, 2026	District release via Channel	"reaching about $64 a year in	"a property with a fair	unstated	First 2026 figure

Date	Where it appeared	Figures as published	Stated basis	Baseline	Assessment
	3000 and Fox 47 ([44]; [45])	the fourth year"	market value of $100,000"		
Aug. 12, 2026	WKOW ([46])	"about $237 — over the course of four years — per every $100,000 worth of property"	"worth of property"	cumulative	Equals $44 + $65 + $64 + $64
Aug.–Oct. 24, 2026	BadgerHomeowner tracker ([41])	$44, $65, $64, $64 per $100K by year	"property value (district)"	the tracker notes the district "doesn't say compared to what"	Still posted 10 days before the vote; year 1 cannot be referendum-only
Sept. 17–21, 2026	District "explanatory page," per Wisconsin Examiner via Civic Media ([47])	$0, $21, $40, $59 per $100K; "$105" in year 2 on an average $500K house	"$100,000 of property"	levels above today's bill	Matches new money ÷ a growing value base (derived)
Sept. 28 and Nov. 3, 2026	Channel 3000 ([48]; [51])	"about $600 over four years" on a $500K home; "$120 over four years" on a $100K home	"a $100,000 home"	cumulative	Correct
Oct. 20 and Nov. 4, 2026	Cap Times ([49]; [54])	"$120 per $100,000 of property value over	"property value"	cumulative	Correct, but set beside an annual

Date	Where it appeared	Figures as published	Stated basis	Baseline	Assessment
		the next four years," beside Waunakee's "$210 per year" on a $500K home			per-home figure
Oct. 21–22, 2026	NBC15/ WMTV ([50])	$0, $105, $200, $295 on $500K under the header "Increase from previous year," then "$600 more annually by the fourth year"	"a home with a fair market value of $500,000"	mislabeled as steps	Year-4 annual figure doubled; almost certainly wrong
Aug.–Oct. 2026	Waunakee fact sheet and FAQ ([35]; [36])	$17 (operating) + $25 (bonds) = $42 per $100K a year; $210 on a $500K home	"estimated fair market value"	annual	See Section 9.4 for discrepancies

Full source links: MCPASD 2022 presentation [31]; Channel 3000, Aug. 12 [44]; WKOW, Aug. 12 [46]; BadgerHomeowner [41]; Civic Media [47]; Channel 3000, Sept. 28 [48]; Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49]; WMTV, Oct. 22 [50]; Waunakee fact sheet [36].

8.2 What each set means

The final $0/$21/$40/$59 figures are **levels above today's bill**, not year-over-year steps. The new authority above $24.9M is $3.0M, $6.2M and $9.7M in years two through four; dividing those amounts by $21, $40 and $59 per $100K implies equalized values of about $14.3B, $15.5B and $16.4B, roughly 7% annual growth from the 2025 base, which is consistent with recent

history (derived). Had the figures been steps, year four would sit $120 per $100K above today, and financing a $9.7M increment at that rate would require an equalized value of only about $8B, below today's base. On a $500,000 home, the referendum therefore costs nothing extra in year one, about $295 a year by year four, and about $600 in total over the four years. The district said it presented per-$100K figures "so individuals could do the math easily depending on the cost of the house" (Civic Media [47]).

The August $44/$65/$64/$64 set cannot be a referendum-only figure, because it charges $44 in a year when the referendum amount is flat. It most likely folded in other levy growth, such as the $325-per-pupil revenue-limit increase, which NBC15 later noted the final figures excluded along with "property valuation changes" (WMTV [50]). That reading is unconfirmed, because the district's page and its explanation of the change were never available to this research. The switch happened between the Aug. 12 release, still unchanged when Channel 3000 edited its story on Sept. 3, and the Sept. 17 information session. None of the outlets noted that the numbers had changed, and a commercial tracker kept publishing the superseded set into late October (BadgerHomeowner [41]). NBC15's "$600 more annually by the fourth year" doubles the year-four figure. The Cap Times' "$120 per $100,000... over the next four years" is correct but sat beside Waunakee's "$210 per year" on a $500,000 home, inviting readers to compare a four-year cumulative figure per $100K with an annual figure per home (Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49]). Expressed on the same basis, MCPASD's year-four cost was the *higher* of the two: $59 per $100K a year against Waunakee's $42, or about $295 against $210 on a $500,000 home.

The skeptics' questions at the Sept. 17 session, attended by about 20 people, show how these numbers landed. A retiree asked, "Who has a $100,000 house in Middleton?... I'd rather see the average house." A realtor and parent wanted "a side-by-side comparison of budgets, one of if the referendum passes and one if it fails" (Civic Media [47]). The district's survey of non-supporters had already flagged "property tax fatigue," a "preference for structural or state-level solutions," and a desire for "greater fiscal discipline, and greater transparency" (MCPASD board recap, secondhand [32]).

8.3 The counterfactual nobody stated

"No added cost in year one" is accurate relative to the 2026-27 bill. Its mirror image went unmentioned. Had the question failed, the $24.9M would have dropped out of the 2027-28 levy limit. By derived arithmetic, that is about **$212 per $100K at 2025 equalized value, or about $191 at 2026 value**, which is roughly **$950–$1,060 a year on a $500,000 home**, as a tax *cut*. The district framed failure as about $24.9M in cuts, roughly 20% of the operating budget, which Hesselbein called "catastrophic" and said "could lead to the closure of an elementary school" (Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49]; WMTV [50]). An organized opposition with a budget would have led with the household saving. WPR's 2020 reporting on Wausau notes that a failed replacement referendum lets taxes fall, which makes any retry a visible tax increase (WPR, Nov. 2020 [86]).

8.4 Assessed versus market value: the basis is part of the number

The basis of "per $100,000" changed between the two campaigns, and no source found explains the change to voters. The 2022 deck's tax slide was titled "Tax Impact: $24.9 million, non-recurring, 4-year period, **$100,000 assessed value**" (MCPASD 2022 presentation [31]). The

2026 release spoke of "a property with a **fair market value** of $100,000," and NBC15 quoted "a home with a fair market value of $500,000" (Channel 3000, Aug. 12 [44]; WMTV [50]). Other outlets used vaguer phrases: "$100,000 worth of property," "$100,000 of property value" and "a $100,000 home."

The 2026 wording is the technically correct one, because school levies are computed on equalized (market) value. By derived arithmetic, the 2022 steps also match the referendum amounts divided by *equalized* value ($53 and $40 per $100K in years two and three, against claims of $53 and $39), which suggests the 2022 "assessed value" label was shorthand rather than the actual basis. The difference matters in a district where ratios ranged from 0.65 to 0.98. A City of Middleton owner who applied a market-value figure to the assessed value on a pre-revaluation bill (78% of market) would have understated the cost by about 22%; in the Village of Cross Plains (65%) the understatement would be about 35%. The correct base was the bill's "estimated fair market value" line, which DOR describes as "calculated by dividing the total assessed value by the average assessment ratio," while noting that "property taxes are levied on the total assessed value" (DOR PB-060 [24]). After the City's 2026 revaluation, assessed value roughly equals market value there, so the two bases coincide for City owners for the first time in years. They still do not coincide in the Village or Berry.

The lesson for 2030 is that a per-$100K figure is only half a number. Without a stated basis, a stated baseline and a stated home, it invites three errors: applying it to the wrong value, reading levels as steps, and comparing it with another district's per-home figure. The same figure also hides that the City's typical home pays the most dollars. At Zillow's September 2026 values, the year-four referendum cost works out to about **$362 a year** on a typical City of Middleton home ($614,311) and about $301 on a typical Village home ($510,868) (derived from Zillow [30]).

8.5 How the 2022 promises held up

Measured by the rate, the 2022 promises held up far better than projected; measured by the bill, taxes still rose.

Year of the 2022 referendum	District's 2022 claim (per $100K)	Actual change in total school rate (per $100K)	Referendum-only cost (per $100K of equalized value)
2023-24 (year 1)	+$7	**−$48**	$73
2024-25 (year 2)	+$53	**−$9**	$126 (+$53)
2025-26 (year 3)	+$39	**+$30**	$166 (+$40)
2026-27 (year 4)	+$36	not yet published	about $191 at 2026 value

Source: derived from DPI [19] and the 2022 presentation [31].

Through year three the district claimed +$99 per $100K and the total rate actually moved −$27. The referendum's own share grew almost exactly as projected in years two and three. Year one's $7 claim, against a standalone $73 cost, implies the district netted out other levy changes it did not describe. Meanwhile, a home that appreciated with the market paid about 3%, 8.5%

and 11% more each year. The per-$100K framing holds value constant, so in a fast-appreciating market it describes neither the rate experience nor the bill experience well. No media fact-check of the 2022 projections was found, which means the district's genuinely good rate record went untold in 2026.

9. Results: Waunakee ran closer to its partisan baseline but is eroding faster

9.1 Different questions on the same ballot

	MCPASD	Waunakee Q1	Waunakee Q2
Type	Non-recurring operating, four years	**Recurring** operating, permanent	General obligation bonds
Amount	$24.9M → $34.6M; $118.5M total	$4.2M in 2027-28 (including $2.1M expiring from 2024), +$2.1M a year to **$10.5M, "to remain at that amount thereafter"**	$97.5M, about $88.7M of it for the high school
Stated purpose	programming, compensation, operations	operations and employee compensation	high school, South Campus, fields, maintenance
District tax claim	$0 / $21 / $40 / $59 per $100K (levels)	$17 per $100K a year	$25 per $100K a year
Year-4 cost, $500K home	about $295 a year	$210 a year combined	(included)
Result (unofficial)	14,263–9,457, **60.1%**	6,787–6,114, **52.6%**	6,647–6,219, **51.7%**
Margin	4,806	673	428
Crowley two-party baseline	77.3%	66.5%	66.5%
Yes minus Dem	–17.1	–13.9	–14.9
Roll-off	7.2%	4.0%	4.3%
Organized Yes committee	yes (parent-led)	none found	none found

Sources: Waunakee referendum page [35]; Waunakee newsletter [37]; Waunakee fact sheet [36]; Dane County Waunakee precincts [16]; Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49].

Waunakee's operating question was permanent: the Tribune noted "that amount would be permanent and continue after 2030-31" (Waunakee Tribune, Aug. 2026 [60]). Channel 3000

described it as running "through the 2030-31 school year," which reads as time-limited and is wrong (Channel 3000, Aug. 2026 [70]). The board directed a policy "to lower annual amounts if the state budget provides resources to match annual budgetary expenditures" (Waunakee presentation [38]), and board vice president Chris Sonne said, "If we don't need the (referendum) money, we're not going to use the money" (Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49]).

9.2 Electorate explains the level; Waunakee actually ran closer to its ceiling

Both Waunakee questions passed narrowly. The Village of Waunakee, with 67% of the votes, carried both (54.5% on the operating question and 52.3% on the bonds). The Town of Westport, the second-largest bloc, rejected the operating question at 49.6% while passing the bonds at 52.3%, and the rural towns of Dane, Springfield and Vienna voted No on both (Dane County [16]). WMTV reported the operating count correctly but repeated it for the bond question, an error the county file corrects (WMTV, Nov. 4 [71]). The bond question carried Village Wards 1–5 by just 16 votes. About 215 voters switching would have defeated the bonds and about 337 the operating question, roughly 1.7% and 2.6% of votes cast.

The 7.5-point difference in Yes share between the districts decomposes cleanly. Waunakee's Democratic baseline was **10.8 points lower** (66.5% against 77.3%), and its gap was **3.2 points smaller** (−13.9 against −17.1): −7.5 = −10.8 + 3.2. The less Democratic electorate explains more than the whole difference; given that electorate, Waunakee ran closer to its partisan ceiling than MCPASD did. Waunakee's electorate was also more conservative on the constitutional amendments, giving the partial-veto limit 41.1% Yes in the Village against 32.5% in MCPASD's non-split units (Dane County State Question 1 [11]). Because the Village and Westport carry 87% of Waunakee's votes, its district-level gap rests on less split-unit guesswork than MCPASD's.

Three reporting units carried both districts' questions on different ballot styles, which holds the whole-unit partisan baseline constant.

Shared reporting unit	Crowley two-party %	MCPASD Yes % (votes)	Waunakee Q1 Yes % (votes)	MCPASD roll-off	Waunakee Q1 roll-off
Town of Westport	65.4	54.0 (224)	49.6 (2,492)	12.8%	6.8%
City of Middleton Wds 14–18	82.2	62.6 (2,262)	65.1 (410)	10.1%	6.6%
Town of Springfield	56.7	43.0 (1,108)	36.9 (358)	5.0%	3.8%

Sources: Dane County MCPASD [4] and Waunakee [16] precinct tables; raw results file [13]. The sub-unit populations differ, so these are not like-for-like voters.

9.3 Four operating asks in four Novembers, and support fell every time

Election	Waunakee question	Structure	Yes %	Dem baseline (two-party)	Yes minus Dem
Nov. 2020	Exceed revenue limit	non-recurring	62.6	Biden 63.9	−1.3
Nov. 2022	#1 Bonds, $175M	debt	52.6	Evers 65.9	−13.2
Nov. 2022	#2 Exceed revenue limit	non-recurring, three years	60.3	Evers 65.9	−5.6
Nov. 2024	Exceed revenue limit	mixed recurring and non-recurring	54.7	Harris 63.6	−8.9
Nov. 2026	Q1 Exceed revenue limit	recurring, to $10.5M	**52.6**	Crowley 66.5	**−13.9**
Nov. 2026	Q2 Bonds, $97.5M	debt	51.7	Crowley 66.5	−14.9

Sources: Dane County Waunakee precinct tables, 2020–2026 [17], [16]; Waunakee Tribune, Nov. 2022 [67]; Waunakee Tribune, Nov. 2024 [65]; Waunakee Tribune, Aug. 2022 [66]. The 2020 and 2024 baselines are presidential, so they are not strictly comparable with governor years.

Waunakee's operating Yes share fell about 10 points over four consecutive asks, and its gap against the Democratic baseline widened about 12.6 points, from −1.3 to −13.9. Between 2022 and 2026 alone, the gap widened **8.3 points** (−5.6 to −13.9), against MCPASD's 3.4. Operating turnout rose 4.1% (12,394 to 12,901 valid votes), but **No rose 24%** (4,923 to 6,114) while Yes fell 9% (7,471 to 6,787); MCPASD's No vote rose 10%. Village operating Yes went 64.5%, 61.6%, 56.6%, 54.5%, and Westport's 59.5%, 58.4%, 52.1%, 49.6%. Operating questions, once Waunakee's easy asks, now poll like its building asks: the 2026 operating result exactly equals the 2022 bond result. Voters named the cycle. At a 2024 information session, an attendee asked whether it was "possible to break a cycle of asking the public for more money to replace funding from temporary referendums" (Waunakee Tribune, Sept. 2024 [64]). The 2026 recurring structure answered that complaint, but it was also Waunakee's largest permanent operating ask, and it passed by its smallest operating margin.

9.4 Lower roll-off, lower stakes and softer tax numbers

Waunakee's question was completed at least as fully as MCPASD's. In the Village, school-question roll-off (3.1–3.2%) equaled that on the three statewide questions (3.0–3.6%), so roll-off did not drive its narrow margin (raw results file [13]). Its messaging differed from MCPASD's in three ways. First, it lowered the stakes. The FAQ said the board "has not created a budget

reduction list" and, if the operating question failed, would "likely consider another operational referendum for April 2027" (Waunakee FAQ [35]). MCPASD, by contrast, warned of "catastrophic" 20% cuts and a possible school closure (Cap Times, Oct. 20 [49]). Second, it leaned on credentials: second-lowest spending per student among Dane County peers ($16,106 against a regional average of $16,839), a debt refinancing that lowered the levy by about $2.39M, and a 2025-26 levy $2.3M under what was allowed, after the board had faced a projected 10.47% levy increase (Waunakee Tribune, 2025 [69]; Waunakee fact sheet [36]; Waunakee presentation [38]). Third, it ran an information-only campaign with seven drop-in sessions, high school tours, virtual sessions, a mailed newsletter with a Spanish version, and no organized Yes committee that the research could find (Waunakee referendum page [35]). In 2022, by contrast, a "coalition of residents" had mailed fliers calling the $175M plan "excessive" (Waunakee Tribune, Oct. 2022 [68]).

Waunakee's tax claims look soft against its own ballot amounts. By derived arithmetic, the new operating levy above 2026-27 would be $2.1M, $4.2M, $6.3M and $8.4M in 2027-28 through 2030-31. On the equalized-value path in the district's own financing plan ($5.52B growing 4.2% a year), that is about $0.35, $0.67, $0.97 and $1.24 per $1,000 if levied in full, against the claimed $0.17. The claim equals only about $1.0M of levy, roughly half the first year's new money. The business director said "in the first two years, the full $2.1 million may not be needed," which may explain part of the difference, but the derivation was never published (Waunakee Tribune, summer 2026 [61]). On the bonds, the PMA Securities plan linked from the FAQ shows the debt-service rate rising from $1.31 in the 2026 levy year to $2.27 by 2029 and $2.20–$2.35 through 2048, a printed "Impact: $0.80" against the 2025-26 base. New-debt-only levy runs about $0.28 per $1,000 in 2027, rising to $0.70–$0.75 in 2029–2031 (derived), well above the flat $0.25 claimed (PMA financing plan [40]). These are flagged discrepancies, not proven errors. Waunakee has made rate-based promises before: in 2022 it said its rate would hold steady even with a $150M-plus referendum, and DPI shows the rate then fell from 10.89 to 9.69 (Waunakee Tribune, Feb. 2022 [72]; DPI [19]).

Both districts entered 2026 with essentially identical school rates: 8.60 in Waunakee and 8.62 in MCPASD for 2025-26. Waunakee's levy rose 26.9% from 2021-22 to 2025-26, almost exactly MCPASD's 27.1%, but its equalized value grew 60.6% against MCPASD's 46.6%, so its rate fell further, from 10.89 to 8.60 (−21%) (DPI [19]). Waunakee's July 2026 annual meeting adopted a draft 2026-27 rate of about 8.80, an estimated $200 increase on a $500,000 home before any referendum effect (Waunakee Tribune, July 2026 [63]). Differences in support between the districts are therefore unlikely to reflect different current burdens per dollar of value.

9.5 What Waunakee's surveys and structure teach MCPASD

Waunakee's spring survey measured 61.5% weighted support for extending $2.1M "for four more years." Voters were then shown a permanent increase to $10.5M, which won 52.6%, about nine points below the survey. Its capital question, surveyed at 51.1%, won 51.7% (Waunakee Tribune, May 2026 [62]; Waunakee Tribune, summer 2026 [61]). MCPASD's survey erred in the opposite direction: 66% raw support and about 47% after likely-voter weighting, according to a secondhand summary, against a 60.1% result (MCPASD board recap [32]; Citizen Portal, secondhand [34]). The 2022 MCPASD survey had tested dose-response directly, finding 64% support at $20M, 58% at $24.9M and 52% at $30M before the $24.9M question won 62.9% (MCPASD 2022 presentation [31]). The transferable lesson is twofold: test the question in the

structure it will actually take, and read a district's survey against its own past calibration rather than as a forecast.

10. Discussion: ambient fatigue set the slide, local tax experience set its map

The results allow the competing explanations to be ranked. The table summarizes the evidence for and against each; the prose that follows weighs them together.

Explanation	Evidence for	Evidence against	Verdict
Partisan polarization: Republicans hardened against the levy	Party still predicts ward Yes (r = 0.79)	Slope flattened; Tiffany gained 266 votes in clean geography while No rose 801; rural towns' No count flat; zero Republican crossover required	**Rejected** as the main cause
Statewide anti-referendum climate and tax fatigue	Pass rate 79% → 57%; Marquette support for school tax referendums 43% for, 57% against; 60% prefer cutting property taxes; Waunakee eroded too	MCPASD lost only 2.8 points	**Strong**, ambient
Serial-renewal and ask-size fatigue	69% → 63% → 60%; final-year ceiling +39%; "continuous ask" quotes; 2022 survey dose-response (64/58/52%); Waunakee −10 points over four asks	Year-one renewal framing held; result beat the weighted survey	**Strong**, cumulative
Rising school bills and values	Village and rural towns: r ≈ −0.66 between typical-home tax growth and Yes change	City (slowest growth) and Madison supplied 61% of new No votes	**Partial**, local
Revaluation	Notices up about	No direct	**Plausible**,

Explanation	Evidence for	Evidence against	Verdict
notice shock in the City	a third; Board of Review Sept. 22; Town's smaller April notices and steady vote	evidence links notices to votes; larger 2024–25 notice jumps elsewhere added no No votes; Madison fell more without a revaluation	untested
Confusing tax numbers	Four incompatible figures; basis switched; "Who has a $100,000 house?"; tracker kept superseded set	Exposure unmeasured; result beat the weighted survey	**Plausible** contributor
Ballot layout and roll-off	City and Town roll-off 2–3 times the statewide questions'; Waunakee's "Flip the Ballot!" units lower	About 550 votes, worth 100–150 on the margin; Village roll-off fell	**Real but small**
Electorate change in a Democratic wave	54% of net new clean-geography ballots became No; Yes fell from 79% to 74% of the Democratic vote	Cannot separate switchers, new voters and skippers	**Likely** contributor
Madison renumbering and split-ward artifacts	Split wards show 8–16 point drops on small samples	Combined west side still fell 3.7 points	Inflates Madison's drop; does not erase it

Sources for the polling entries: Marquette Law School Poll, Feb. 2026 [82]; Marquette Today, June 2026 [83]. WPR, citing a later Marquette reading, reported 48% for and 51% against (WPR preview [75]); the figures differ by wave, but the direction is the same.

The polarization story fails every test the ward data allow. If Republicans had driven the slide, the slope of Yes on Democratic share would have steepened, the rural towns would have added No votes and the Republican vote would have grown enough to account for the new No votes. None of that happened. The ambient explanations fit better. Marquette's February 2026 poll found only **43%** of Wisconsin voters would back a school tax referendum, down from 52% in

June 2025, and **60%** preferred cutting property taxes to raising school spending, the highest share in 26 polls since 2013 and up from 42–46% in fall 2022 (Marquette Law School Poll [82]). Marquette's own summary describes a trend "toward opposing local school referendum proposals" (Marquette Today [83]). Serial-ask fatigue adds a cumulative layer: MCPASD's three-cycle slide, Waunakee's four-cycle slide and the opponents' "continuous ask" language all point the same way. The Wisconsin Association of School Boards' Dan Rossmiller described the mechanism in 2020: when a non-recurring referendum expires, "very typically the school district is coming to ask for a bigger amount in the subsequent ask" (WPR, Nov. 2020 [86]).

Ambient forces predict a decline everywhere. They do not explain why the Town of Middleton held while the City of Middleton, the Madison wards and the Village slid. Local tax experience supplies part of that map. In the Village and the rural towns, the pattern is the conventional one: fast appreciation shifted levy share toward those places, bills printed the district's highest rates or followed large revaluations, and Yes eroded, through new No votes in the Village and lost Yes votes in the towns. In the City, the bill story fails and the notice story fits the timing, but it rests on one well-placed coincidence. Two further City facts matter. The City has the highest Democratic share in the district, so it had the most Democratic support to lose, and it had the highest roll-off, which is consistent with conflicted Democrats moving from Yes to the blank line as well as to No. And because its homes are the most valuable, the same per-$100K figure means the largest dollar amounts there. Madison remains the least explained. Its wards had no revaluation, middling tax growth and the largest drop in Yes share, and the uncertainty about split-ward partisanship and renumbering is largest there.

The strongest alternative explanations deserve a direct hearing. One is regression from an unusually favorable 2022: that year's case was easy to make, because the state had given districts $0 per pupil for two years and COVID money was about to run out, while by 2026 the state was giving $325 a year and levies were already rising 8–11%. That reading fits the data and reinforces the main conclusion, since it is another way of saying that the tax-fairness argument got harder among Democrats who follow state politics. A second is demographic change, such as aging long-tenured homeowners or newcomer renters, which the research could not test because Census data were unreachable. A third is campaign effects. MCPASD had an organized, parent-led Yes committee; Waunakee had none that the research could find, and Waunakee lost more against its own 2022 baseline. Partisanship and campaign structure are confounded across the two districts, so the comparison cannot isolate the committee's effect.

The synthesis is a coalition model. MCPASD's Yes vote is a Democratic base multiplied by tax trust: trust that the bill is fair, that the district is frugal and that the state, not the district, is to blame for the gap. Party identity sets the ceiling; trust determines how much of it is reached. The 2026 wave confirmed the model from the other side, because more Democrats voted and Yes did not rise. Every mechanism that eroded support in 2026 worked through trust among Democrats: bills in the Village, notices in the City, numbers that changed mid-campaign, and a fourth consecutive ask in Waunakee. That is good news for 2030 in one respect. Several of those mechanisms, including the tax table, its timing, the fail scenario, the receipts and the ballot reminder, are under the district's and the campaign's control.

11. Limitations

The 2026 counts are unofficial until the canvass, which is due by Nov. 17, 2026. The ward tables should be re-downloaded and every derived figure re-run once the official results post. The margin will not change, but individual ward figures, and especially the under-vote counts that drive the roll-off findings, may.

Every partisan finding is ecological. The defection figures are bounds and model estimates under stated assumptions, not observations of how any Democrat or Republican voted. A quarter of MCPASD's referendum votes come from split units, where the partisan share describes a whole town or Madison ward rather than its MCPASD slice; the Berry, Springfield, Town of Cross Plains, Westport and Madison split-ward gaps are approximations. The unit counts are small (10 to 24 units for the regressions, eight municipalities for the property correlations), so slope changes and correlations are directional.

Roll-off before 2026 cannot be measured directly, because Dane County publishes under-votes only for the current election, so 2022 roll-off is estimated from fully-inside units. No ballot style from either year was inspected, which leaves the layout explanation for the City and Town of Middleton untested. Ward changes, and Madison's renumbering in particular, make some single-unit comparisons unreliable.

The property and tax data have specific gaps. No 2022 municipal-level DOR file survives online, so municipal comparisons begin in 2023 or 2024. Whole-municipality DOR measures stand in for the MCPASD slices of split towns. Zillow's ZIP codes straddle municipal lines, and DOR's single-year town estimates swing widely on few sales. The 2026-27 levy and rate, the 2026 assessment ratios and any December 2026 bill were not yet public. Whether the Village of Cross Plains revalued for 2026 is unconfirmed, and the City's notice text is known only secondhand.

The messaging record has its own gaps. The district's 2026 tax page, the baseline of its August figures and the reason the figures changed were never available, because the district site blocked automated access. The 47% weighted survey figure rests on a secondhand summary. Waunakee's derivation of its $0.17 and $0.25 claims was not published, so the discrepancies flagged here are not proven errors. Field-campaign facts from the Yes committee's internal tracker were not independently verified. Finally, nothing here separates causes with confidence. One election with ward-level data cannot isolate fatigue, structure, stakes framing, notices and roll-off from one another; that requires individual-level data the campaign does not yet have.

12. Implications and recommendations for 2030

12.1 The starting position: a $34.6M floor, a midterm date and a new state government

The 2026 authority covers 2027-28 through 2030-31, so new authority must be in place for 2031-32 (WKOW, Nov. 4 [52]). The natural renewal date is **Nov. 5, 2030**, another midterm. The best Wisconsin evidence favors it. Kogan, Lavertu and Peskowitz, matching more than 10,000 school measures in four states to voter files, find no significant passage penalty for Wisconsin midterms relative to presidential elections (−0.07), but a **23-point lower passage probability in April spring elections** ($p < .001$), whose electorates hold about 10 points more voters aged 65 and over and 4 points fewer voters with children at home (Kogan, Lavertu & Peskowitz 2018

[84]). The study's data end around 2016, so current risks in every election type are likely larger. April 2, 2030 makes sense only as a deliberate first try with November as the fallback, and a November 2030 failure would leave only an April 2031 retry, after budgets are set. Nov. 7, 2028, the highest-turnout and most parent-heavy electorate available, is the only plausible date for converting part of the base to recurring authority, and that option is speculative (dates computed).

The ask will start where 2026 ended, at **$34.6M**, and Waunakee shows that repeated asks erode support by a few points a cycle. A 60% baseline should not be assumed. The state is the swing variable. Democrats now hold the governorship and both legislative chambers (Wikipedia, 2026 gubernatorial election [95]), and Senate Democratic Leader Dianne Hesselbein, the board president's spouse, promised special-education and general-aid action "in January" (Civic Media [47]). A meaningful revenue-limit or aid increase in the 2027–29 budget would shrink the 2030 ask. A token one would weaken the campaign's central argument, that the state will not fix the gap, while leaving most of the ask in place. Governance moves first. Two Area board seats convert to open, any-resident seats in April 2027, after electors approved the change 60–46 at the Sept. 22, 2026 annual meeting (Open Seats MCPASD [42]). The board those races produce will set the size and structure of the 2030 question.

12.2 Questions to settle before the board picks a number

Question	Why it matters	How to answer it
Who are the 22–27% of Democratic-voting participants who voted No, and what would move them?	They are the swing; Republicans did not grow the No vote	Post-election survey with ward identifiers; focus groups in City Wds 5–8/21 and 9–13/19/22/24 and Village Wds 1–6
Did the City's revaluation notices move votes?	Decides whether 2030 messaging must be timed around assessment calendars	City assessor's parcel-level 2025→2026 assessment change by ward, matched to ward Yes change; a survey item on notice recall
Did the Village revalue for 2026, and what will December bills show there?	The Village core is at 51.8%; a move from 0.65 to market would raise notices about 53%	Village assessor; the Treasurer's 2026 mill-rate sheet in December
Why did roll-off double in the City and Town of Middleton but fall in the Village and Madison?	About 550 lost votes, possibly fixable	2022 and 2026 ballot styles from all eight clerks, mapped for question placement
What did the 2026-27 levy and rate turn out to be, and what did the TID closure do to bills?	Tests the "rate falls, bills rise" record and sets the base for 2030 figures	DPI's FY2026-27 page; the 2026 Treasurer sheet

Question	Why it matters	How to answer it
What will the 2027–29 and 2029–31 state budgets do?	Changes both the size of the ask and the core message	Track the budgets; model three state scenarios before the 2029 survey
Does the ratified partial-veto amendment touch the $325-a-year increase running to 2425?	That increase underpins the revenue-limit baseline	A legal read from WASB, DPI or the Legislative Fiscal Bureau
Renew as non-recurring, or convert part to recurring?	Each renewal starts at the last ceiling; only 3 of 8 recurring operating questions passed in Nov. 2026; Waunakee's passed with its smallest operating margin	Survey both structures as they would be worded; model the levy paths
What does a household's bill look like if the question fails?	Unstated in 2026: about $950–$1,060 a year on a $500,000 home	District side-by-side pass and fail budgets and bills
Were the promised $5M in cuts delivered, and where?	Answers "room to cut" and "continuous ask"	An annual public cuts tracker (MCPASD [33])
How should the next survey be weighted?	Raw 66%, weighted about 47%, actual 60.1%	Calibrate weights against 2026 ward results and turnout
Did the door program move turnout?	Allocates 2030 volunteer hours	WEC voter history for worked versus unclaimed turfs
How did the electorate's age, tenure and household makeup change?	Tests the senior and newcomer hypotheses	ACS tables B01001, B11005, B25003 and B25077 for the MCPASD unified-district geography

12.3 What to do differently

Build a persuasion universe of Democratic homeowners, not only a turnout list. The 2026 field plan worked 45 turfs covering 2,102 doors drawn from lists of likely supporters (Referendum canvass volunteer plan [43]). That is the right list for turnout and the wrong one for the votes that slipped away. A 2030 program needs a second universe of Democratic-voting, long-tenured homeowners in City Wards 5–8/21 and 9–13/19/22/24 and Village Wards 1–6, reached with a different script and different messengers, such as retirees, longtime neighbors and realtors. The scale argument is simple. The City of Middleton casts **47% of all referendum votes**, so a three-point recovery there adds about **670 votes to the margin**, more than any plausible movement in the rural towns combined. Older voters who resist state school

spending are far more willing to fund their *own* district when home values and local ties are at stake (Balsdon & Brunner 2003 [85]), so the message to them should lead with home values and neighbors rather than inflation charts.

Publish one tax table, with its basis, baseline and a real house, before the board votes. The 2026 record shows what happens otherwise. The table should state the basis in the voter's language ("per $100,000 of the *estimated fair market value* printed on your tax bill, not your assessed value"), the baseline ("compared with your 2030-31 bill"), year-by-year levels and the four-year total, the figure for the typical home in each municipality (in 2026 terms, about $362 a year by year four in the City and about $301 in the Village), and the fail scenario. It should carry a date, and any later change should be announced with a reason. Hand it to reporters on the day of the board vote, correct errors within 24 hours, and ask commercial trackers to update superseded figures. An online calculator that asks for the fair-market line on the voter's own bill answers "Who has a $100,000 house?" before anyone asks it.

Time the message around the assessment calendar. DOR requires every municipality's average assessment to sit within 10% of market at least once every five years (DOR PB-060 [24]). The Village of Cross Plains (0.65) and the Town of Berry (0.67) were far outside that band in 2025, so revaluations there are likely before or near 2030 (inference). The campaign should collect every municipality's revaluation schedule by 2029, work with assessors on a short "your notice is not your bill" explainer, and avoid a 2030 in which notices jump a third during the campaign without explanation. Where a revaluation or TID closure lowers the printed school rate, as the City's did in 2026, say so plainly.

State the counterfactual before the opposition does. The 2026 Yes coalition never faced an organized opponent, and No still reached 40% (Civic Media [47]). A funded 2030 opposition would lead with the **roughly $1,000 a year** that failure would save a $500,000 home. The district should publish the side-by-side pass and fail budgets that skeptical voters asked for, and the campaign should test its answer early: what $34.6M in cuts would do to class sizes, buildings, programs and home values.

Make "flip the ballot" standard with all eight clerks, in writing, by August. Waunakee printed "Make Sure to Flip the Ballot!" in its mailed materials, and in every reporting unit the two districts shared, its question had lower roll-off than MCPASD's (Waunakee newsletter [37]). In 2030 the campaign should ask all eight municipal clerks early for neutral reminder language on ballot instructions, absentee envelopes and poll-worker scripts, put "it's on the back" on every sign rider, hanger and post, and request the ballot styles so the layout hypothesis can finally be tested.

Offer Waunakee's levy-less pledge, and post receipts every year. Waunakee's board directed a policy to lower annual referendum amounts if the state budget provides resources (Waunakee presentation [38]). A similar public pledge from the MCPASD board, tied to the 2027–29 state budget, would turn "the continuous ask" into a shared goal and give tax-weary Democrats a way to be pro-school and anti-levy at the same time. Pair it with an annual "what the referendum bought, what we cut, what the rate did" report. It should track the promised $5M in cuts and tell the true and favorable rate story: through year three, the district projected +$99 per $100K and the total rate moved −$27.

Archive the data the county does not keep, starting now. Dane County publishes under-votes only for the current election, so the 2026 raw results file should be downloaded again after the canvass and stored before the next election replaces it (Dane County raw results file [13]). The same applies to the official ward tables, DOR's municipal reports (which drop off after three years), the City's parcel-level assessment changes and the ACS district tables. The campaign should also build a 2026-to-2030 ward crosswalk now. Barring annexations, the November 2030 election should use the same post-2024 ward framework, because rewarding after the 2030 Census comes later (inference), which would make 2026-to-2030 comparisons cleaner than this paper's. By the campaign's internal tracker, which was not independently verified, only 25 of the 45 turfs were claimed, about 40% of targeted doors went unvisited and locked apartment buildings were skipped. Once WEC voter history updates, comparing turnout in worked and unclaimed turfs is the only local evidence the campaign will have on whether its doors moved votes.

Survey the structure that will be on the ballot, and calibrate against 2026. Waunakee's operating question ran about nine points below its survey after its structure changed from a four-year renewal to a permanent increase (Waunakee Tribune, May 2026 [62]). MCPASD's weighted survey understated its result by about 13 points. The 2029 survey should test the exact structures under consideration, including a straight non-recurring renewal from $34.6M and a partial recurring conversion, and its weights should be calibrated against 2026 ward results and turnout rather than read as a forecast.

Study the Town of Middleton and watch the Village of Cross Plains. The Town is the one large community that held its partisan baseline while its ballots grew 14%, and its Wards 5–8 ran almost seven points ahead of the partisan fit. Whatever explains that, whether new subdivisions with young families, proximity to schools, or the smaller and earlier 2026 notices, is the best local model for what works, and a dozen interviews there would be worth more than another statewide poll. The Village is the opposite case: the closest large unit, the fastest-appreciating municipality and the highest printed school rate. It needs local listening sessions well before 2030.

Weigh the recurring option with Waunakee's caution. A recurring conversion would end the four-year cycle that voters now name as a grievance. But only 3 of 8 recurring operating questions passed statewide in November 2026 (Civic Media [73]), and Waunakee's recurring question passed with its smallest operating margin. The board should model the levy paths of both options before choosing, and should keep the Yes coalition organized through the April 2027 board races so that whichever structure it chooses has a campaign behind it.

13. Conclusion

The 2026 vote changes how MCPASD's referendum risk should be understood. The danger is not a Republican backlash; the town-and-country No vote did not grow, and the Democratic wave added voters without adding Yes votes. The danger is a slow loss of trust inside the district's own Democratic majority, expressed differently in different places: through bills in the Village, through notices and blank ballots in the City, and through an ask that keeps getting bigger everywhere. That diagnosis is more hopeful than the topline suggests, because most of the trust mechanisms are controllable. The district's actual rate record since 2022 beats its promises, yet the campaign never told that story. The tax table switched mid-campaign. The

cost of failure was never stated. And a cheap ballot reminder that worked next door was left mostly unused.

The comparison with Waunakee adds urgency. A district can keep passing operating questions while its margin erodes cycle after cycle, until a fourth ask passes by 673 votes. MCPASD's 2030 question will be its third straight four-year renewal and will start from a $34.6M ceiling. The analyst's most valuable work is not the 2030 field plan but the four years before it: archiving data that will otherwise disappear, finding out from individual voters what the ward data can only bound, and putting the receipts, the tax table and the state's budget choices in front of Middleton's skeptical Democrats long before anyone prints a yard sign.

Appendix A. Counterfactual: the referendum without a blue wave

Question. Would the 2026 question have done better, worse or about the same in a midterm without a national Democratic wave?

Short answer. About the same, and possibly better. Under every scenario modeled here the question still passes. The partisan tide moves MCPASD's result by only one to three points. The variable that could sink a future question is the share of Democratic-leaning voters who vote Yes, not the partisan mix of the electorate.

A.1 What the wave did inside MCPASD

The 2026 wave showed up in MCPASD mainly as extra turnout, not as a more Democratic electorate. The district-wide Democratic two-party share for governor rose only from 76.6% (Evers, 2022) to 77.3% (Crowley, 2026) [7][8]. In reporting units fully inside the district, 1,492 more ballots were cast than in 2022 [5][6]. Crowley ran 1,265 votes ahead of Evers there, but the referendum gained only 175 Yes votes against 801 No votes, and 516 more ballots left the question blank [4][13]. These are net changes. They cannot show whether the new voters themselves voted No, or whether returning 2022 voters switched while the newcomers split evenly. Either way, the extra turnout produced few new Yes votes.

A.2 Method

The scenarios use a simple two-group ecological model (Goodman regression). Each reporting unit's Yes share is modeled as a weighted mix of a Democratic Yes rate and a Republican Yes rate, with the unit's Democratic two-party governor share as the weight. The model is fitted across reporting units with at least 20 referendum votes, weighted by referendum votes, using the ward tables in Sections 4 and 6 [4][7][8]. Two fits bracket the estimates:

Fit (2026)	Units	Democratic Yes rate	Republican Yes rate	Predicted district Yes
All units	24	0.76	0.07	60.3% (actual 60.1%)
Units fully inside MCPASD	10	0.73	0.22	61.4% (recentered to 60.1%)

The same fits for 2022 give a Democratic Yes rate of 0.79–0.82. The decline to 0.73–0.76 in 2026 is the defection described in Section 6. Every scenario below holds the 2026 rates fixed and changes only the electorate, except the last, which also lowers the Democratic Yes rate. Margins assume about 23,720 votes on the question, as in 2026. The caveats in Section 2 apply in full. These are ward aggregates with few units, the Republican rate is poorly identified, and results are directional, not forecasts.

A.3 Scenarios

Scenario	Electorate assumption	Estimated Yes	Estimated margin
Actual 2026 (blue wave)	Democratic share 77.3%	60.1%	+4,806
Neutral year, composition only	Democratic share back to 2022's 76.6%	~59.8%	~+4,650
Neutral year, turnout effect	2022-like turnout; the extra 2026 voters absent	up to ~62.9% (upper bound)	up to ~+6,130
Red-leaning midterm	Democratic share 4 points lower (~73%)	~57.6–58.1%	~+3,600 to +3,850
Red-leaning midterm with sharper tax revolt	~73% Democratic, and the Democratic Yes rate falls to 0.70	~53–56%	~+1,500 to +2,800

The "neutral year" result is a range because of the ambiguity in A.1. If the 2026 slip came from returning voters changing their minds, removing the wave's extra voters changes almost nothing (about 59.8%). If it came from the extra voters themselves, a 2022-sized electorate would have produced something close to 2022's 62.9%. The true effect probably lies between, so a reasonable central guess is that the wave cost the referendum zero to two points. That fits Section 5's finding that high turnout in 2026 did not mean a more school-supportive electorate. It also qualifies the general pattern that larger, younger, presidential-year electorates help school measures [84]. Higher turnout helps when the added voters are parents and school-connected households, not when they are low-engagement voters drawn out by a nationalized race.

A.4 Break-even points

Holding the other parameter at its 2026 value, the question falls below 50% if either:

- the district's Democratic two-party share drops to about **57–62%** (from 77%), roughly Waunakee's electorate (66.5%) minus several more points [16], or

- the Democratic Yes rate drops to about **0.60–0.63** (from 0.73–0.76), meaning roughly two in five Democratic-voting referendum voters choose No.

The first is implausible for MCPASD in any foreseeable midterm. The second is a continuation of the trend already measured: the Democratic Yes rate fell about five to six points from 2022 to 2026, and another two drops of that size would put the district at the edge.

A.5 Implications

1. **Plan for a neutral or red-leaning 2030 midterm, but don't fear it most.** A hostile national climate costs perhaps two to three points. That hurts, but it does not decide the result.
2. **Treat Democratic defection as the main risk.** The model's most sensitive input is how Democratic-leaning homeowners vote, which is why Sections 6, 7 and 12 focus on the City of Middleton, the Madison wards and the Village of Cross Plains.
3. **Don't treat high turnout as a strategy.** Turnout programs should target school-connected households. Raising general turnout in a nationalized year brought in voters who skipped the question or voted No.
4. **Re-run this appendix after the Nov. 17 canvass** and, if possible, with voter-file turnout data that separates new voters from repeat voters. That would resolve the A.1 ambiguity.

Appendix B. Who counts as a Democrat? Assumptions and crossover voters

Wisconsin voters do not register by party, and ballots are secret, so this paper never observes a single Democrat or Republican. Every partisan figure is built from how each reporting unit voted for governor. This appendix states those assumptions plainly and tests the one most likely to mislead: voters who split their ticket.

B.1 What the labels mean

Label in this paper	What it actually measures	What it does not mean
"Democrat," "Democratic-voting participant"	A referendum voter in the Democratic column for governor: Evers in 2022, Crowley in 2026	A registered or self-identified Democrat
"Republican," "Republican-voting participant"	A referendum voter in the Republican column for governor: Michels in 2022, Tiffany in 2026	A registered or self-identified Republican
"Democratic share"	Democratic votes ÷ (Democratic + Republican votes) for governor, averaged across units by referendum votes	The share of party members

Four assumptions sit under every partisan number:

1. **Referendum voters split for governor the way their whole unit did.** Third-party votes and skipped governor races are dropped.
2. **A unit's governor split applies to its MCPASD voters.** This fails in split units, where the governor count includes voters outside the district (Section 2.4).
3. **Party Yes rates are the same in every ward** (Goodman fits only). A City Democrat and a Town Democrat are assumed to vote Yes at the same rate.
4. **The governor column is the party.** A Republican or independent who voted for Crowley counts as a Democrat. Sections B.2 and B.3 test this one.

B.2 Two kinds of crossover voters push in opposite directions

- **Republicans who vote Yes** stay in the Republican column but support the schools. Each one supplies a Yes vote that would otherwise be credited to Democrats, so *more* Democrats must have voted No to land at 60.1%. The 22% floor in Section 6.3 assumes there are none.
- **Republicans and independents who vote for the Democratic governor**, then vote No, sit in the Democratic column. They inflate the "Democrats voting No" figure, so the more of them there are, the *fewer* loyal Democrats voted No.

Table B.1 shows how the 2026 figure moves under both. Rows set crossovers (voted for Crowley but lean Republican) as a share of all referendum voters. Columns set the Yes rate among Tiffany voters. Crossovers are assumed to vote Yes at the same rate as other Republicans.

Table B.1. Share of loyal Democrats who voted No in 2026 (%)

Crossovers, share of referendum voters	Tiffany voters 0% Yes	7% Yes	15% Yes	22% Yes
None	22.2	24.3	26.6	28.7
3%	19.1	21.5	24.3	26.7
5%	16.8	19.5	22.6	25.3
10%	10.7	14.1	17.9	21.3
15%	3.5	7.7	12.6	16.8

Source: computed from the district totals, Yes at 60.1% of 23,720 referendum votes and a Crowley two-party share of 77.3% weighted by referendum votes (Dane County governor 2026 [8]; Dane County referendum 2026 [4]). The 7% and 22% columns are the two Goodman estimates for Republicans in Appendix A.2; 15% is the "more realistic" case in Section 6.3. The top-left cell is the Section 6.3 floor (22.3% there; the difference is rounding). If crossovers voted Yes at 30%, between the two parties, the crossover rows move up to about 4 points higher.

B.3 What crossovers can and cannot explain

They can lower the level. If one referendum voter in ten was a crossover who voted like a Republican, the share of loyal Democrats voting No falls to roughly 11–21%, depending on how

many Tiffany voters said Yes. "At least one in five Crowley voters voted No" stays true. Whether one in five *loyal Democrats* did depends on assumptions ward data cannot settle.

They cannot explain the Democratic No vote away. For every Crowley voter who voted No to be a crossover, crossovers would have to make up about 17% of all referendum voters district-wide, and 24% in City Wards 5–8/21, every one of them voting No. That would mean about two in five MCPASD voters lean Republican, in a district where the Republican candidate for governor won 23%.

They cannot explain the rise since 2022. Holding the crossover share the same in both years, the share of loyal Democrats voting No still rises by about 4 to 5 points under every assumption tested:

Assumption	2022	2026	Change
No crossovers, no Republican Yes	17.9	22.2	+4.3
No crossovers, 15% Republican Yes	22.5	26.6	+4.1
5% crossovers, no Republican Yes	12.1	16.8	+4.7
5% crossovers, 15% Republican Yes	18.1	22.6	+4.5
10% crossovers, 15% Republican Yes	13.1	17.9	+4.8

Source: computed as in Table B.1, with the 2022 district totals (Yes 62.9% of 23,204 votes; Evers 76.6%) (Dane County governor 2022 [7]).

New crossovers explain at most part of the widening gap. If the wave added crossovers who voted No, the Democratic share would have grown by about as much as the gap widened. On the governor measure the Democratic share grew 0.7 points while the gap widened 3.4, so new crossovers explain at most about a fifth of it. On the attorney-general measure the share grew 3.2 points against a 6.0-point widening, at most about half. This assumes few 2022 crossovers returned to the Republican column while new ones arrived; heavy churn of that kind would leave the bound loose. On either measure, at least half the widening came from voters in the Democratic column voting No more often than in 2022.

B.4 Bottom line

The defensible sentence is: **at least one in five people who voted for the Democratic candidate for governor voted No on the referendum, up from at least 18% in 2022.** Ticket-splitting on the scale of one voter in ten could bring the share of loyal Democrats voting No down to about one in ten, but it cannot account for the increase. Telling lifelong Democrats

from ticket-splitters requires individual data, such as a post-election survey that asks party identification alongside the vote.

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Access notes: "secondhand" marks sources known only from a search-engine summary or a page that later failed to load. Dane County 2026 results are unofficial as of Nov. 5, 2026.

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